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Agatha Christie and Her
Murderers: a Case Study of
the Miss Marple Novels

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1. Introduction

In his *Bloody Murder*, Julian Symons writes: “John Dickson Carr, writing in 1935, thought that statistics would show the secretary to be still the most common murderer in crime fiction, although no doubt members of the murderess’s family would have come first if they had been admitted as a category” (95). Agatha Christie (1890-1976) is the writer most commonly associated with crimes and crime fiction.¹ However, I could not remember reading about a murdering secretary in any of her novels. This suggested that who the murderers actually were in her novels would be worth writing about, in order to prove the truth of Dickson Carr’s statement or to demonstrate that her novels were more complex and contained more variety in their plots than is commonly assumed.²

In this thesis I use the following twelve novels by Christie featuring her woman detective Miss Marple as the chief investigator: *The Murder at the Vicarage* (1930), *The Body in the Library* (1942), *The Moving Finger* (1943), *A Murder Is Announced* (1950), *They Do It with Mirrors* (1952), *A Pocket Full of Rye* (1953), *4.50 from Paddington* (1957), *The Mirror Crack’d from Side to Side* (1962), *A Caribbean Mystery* (1964), *At Bertram’s Hotel* (1965), *Nemesis* (1971) and *Sleeping Murder* (1976).³ These books, and this protagonist, “have provided the critical perspective on Christie” (Light 64). Apart from this, the Miss Marple series is the most well-known series next to the Poirot books, and Christie preferred this investigator to Poirot, “who grew tedious and whom she tried on several occasions to kill off” (Shaw and Vanacker 2). The Miss Marple series should thus be the one to be investigated to prove or disprove a statement of “common knowledge”.

My aim is to examine whether Agatha Christie uses variation in the Miss Marple novels. It is often thought that she does not do this: “Christie often and inaccurately is accused of being a slave to convention: repeatedly rewriting the same novel under different titles, all with pedestrian style, cardboard characters, unvarying settings, and only a few plot tricks that

she replays endlessly to baffle her dim readers” (Knepper, “The Curtain Falls” 81). Seeking to examine the truth of this, and similar statements⁴, I will limit my investigation to her “cardboard characters”: I examine the murderers, the victims, and the weapons that are used. As Agatha Christie is often accused of being a formulaic writer, using stock characters and stock situations to explore the infinite variety of human resourcefulness in how to kill another human, it is appropriate to analyse her use of these elements in a quantitative way.

The murderers form my first topic. In order to find out whether Christie varies these characters, I examine their social class and their sex. The majority of murderers seem to come from one particular class and I investigate whether there is a connection between their social status and their motives. With regard to the sex of the characters, I compare the percentage of male and female murderers and consider also their social class. I also investigate if their motives for committing the crimes differ. The victims, my second topic, are examined for their social class and their sex. With regard to the social class, I again investigate if the majority seem to come from one particular social class and compare this to that of the murderers. I also investigate whether different social classes die for different motives. With regard to the sex of the victims, I show that there are significantly more female victims in these Christie novels, and I also consider their social status. I also investigate whether male and female victims die for different reasons and I examine whether male and female murderers prefer to kill victims of their own sex. Finally, I look at the murder weapons, establishing which kinds are used to consider whether Christie varies these and whether the assumption that she only uses domestic weapons is in fact correct. By looking at whether a particular kind of weapon is used by different social classes and by male and female murderers, I will be able to tell if Christie uses variation in this case. This last examination will contribute to a judgment about Christie’s variations in her depiction of murderers.

These investigations will contribute to a reconsideration of the claim that Christie is a formulaic writer. Both Light's work on social class in the detective fiction genre, her examination of Christie's weaponry, and Shaw and Vanacker's discussion of the sex of characters, have led my investigation. The examination of the social classes is further supported by Humble's analysis of the reflection of social changes in women's writing from the 1920s to the 1950s, and the choice of weaponry is examined in the light of Christie's life with the aid of Morgan's biographical works. Other works, both on Christie's writing and more generally on the genre to which she belongs, have also been considered and drawn on where necessary. I provide plot summaries of all the stories in an appendix.

2. Survey

2.1. The murderers

In this chapter, I examine the murderers in Christie's novels, looking at their social class and sex. In this last section, I do not use a gender approach, which focuses on the difference between masculine and feminine. Instead, I use the term sex to distinguish between male and female characters in the novels.

2.1.1. Social class

Social class is a relevant topic to be examined when studying detective fiction as it "has long played a role in crime fiction": it "may appear as a theme, as background information or description, or as the unconscious attitude of the author" (Miller 73). In *The Times Literary Supplement*, "the English detective story" is described as "'oddly classbound, emanating from and imbued with the mores of a group one must describe fairly closely as professional middle-middle to upper-middle class'" (qtd. in Barnard 38). Establishing the

social status of the murderers requires a method of classification (see below). Even though it is said that Agatha Christie is “a shrewd judge of the gradations of wealth and social class” (Shaw and Vanacker 32), it has not always been easy for me to determine which social class the characters belong to. A full overview of my motivations for these classifications is included and the results collected and further interpreted. As I go on to investigate whether there is a visible relationship between the murderers’ motives and their social class, I link an overview and a discussion of the murderers’ motives before linking these to the social class and commenting on the relationship between them.

2.1.1.1. Allocation of the murderers to social classes

In determining the social status of both the murderers and the victims, factors that range “from fairly solid material determinants such as income, property, work, education, accent, and family background, to the often crucial minutiae of taste, manners, dress, forms of entertainment, and tricks of speech” are used (Humble 85). I follow Alan S. C. Ross’ division of the social classes into upper-, middle-, and lower-class (9). However, Humble notes that “after the First World War” (57), attitudes to and perceptions of the middle-class began to change as it underwent a “massive increase in size”. “It was somewhat augmented from above, as members of the upper class lost caste with property and incomes, but most significant was the influx from below” (74). Because of this growth, “the divisions within the class became more marked” (83). As the people who belonged to this class “became increasingly selfconscious” (57), it is therefore no surprise that “the feminine middlebrow”⁵ was peculiarly devoted to the anatomizing of middle-classness” (59).⁶ In order to reflect this social change in my investigation, I have decided to divide this class into upper-middle-, lower-middle-, and middle-class.

In the twelve novels studied, foreigners both occur as murderers and as victims. They are thus both significant to the plots and operate within certain class boundaries in the text. I therefore include them in my classification and give them an honorary class status.

The Murder at the Vicarage (1930): Anne Protheroe becomes an upper-middle-class lady by marrying Colonel Protheroe. It is, however, more likely that she already belonged to this class before the marriage, as people would have gossiped if she had not. In any case, her social status can be determined by looking at the Protheroe property. For a discussion of this, see the discussion of Colonel Protheroe's social status in 2.2.1.1.

Lawrence Redding, on the other hand, is not Anne's equal. He rents a cottage (183) in St Mary Mead, so he is not poverty-stricken, but a cottage is very different from the riches of Old Hall. Moreover, he is also "a good amateur actor" and "a clever painter" (23). So he is déclassé in comparison with Anne. I think it is safe to suppose that he is middle-class. He might also be a stranger: "He has, I think, Irish blood in his veins" (23). This is very telling as Colin Watson writes: "Foreign was synonymous with criminal in nine novels out of ten, and the conclusion is inescapable that most people found this perfectly natural" (123). In any case, the Irishness is stressed, which may be an indication of untrustworthiness. (See e.g. also Rudi Scherz and Mitzi in *A Murder Is Announced* and Michael Gorman in *At Bertram's Hotel*. They are also foreigners and suspicious.)

The Body in the Library (1942): Josephine "Josie" Turner and Mark Gaskell are the murdering couple in this novel. I would say that Josie is middle-class and Mark is upper-class. Josie, as Miss Marple says, has "to earn her living" as a dancer at the hotel, while Mark can stay there as a guest. Mark is thought to be "well-to-do" (107) even though the reader knows that he is penniless. This is because he married money by marrying Mr Jefferson's daughter (cf. the large amount of money Jefferson gave to both of his children when they got married).

Yet, he manages his expensive lifestyle by living with Mr Jefferson and consequently off him. Adelaide mentions that she and her son “have lived with him practically ever since, and he’s paid for all our living expenses.” This means that she “never had to worry” (147). As for Josie, there are no indications that she is hard up. In fact, Melchett is stunned by all the beauty products he finds in her room (92), which means that she has money to spend.

The Moving Finger (1943): Mr Symmington is a solicitor who employs three servants: a governess to look after his two sons, a cook and the maid Agnes. He enjoys social respect and organizes bridge parties. He also intends to send his boys to “Winhays-my old prep. school” (149). The house he lives in is equipped with among other things a drawing-room, a schoolroom, a nursery and a garden with a tennis court. It seems as though he lives in an upper-class environment, but as he has to work for money I think he is more probably upper-middle-class. Nancy Mitford wrote in 1954: “The purpose of the aristocrat is most emphatically not to work for money” (43). Evelyn Waugh noted that when aristocrats work for money “they become middle-class” (66).

A Murder Is Announced (1950): I think that Charlotte Blacklock is middle-class. She lives in Little Paddocks and lets rooms to her cousins Patrick Simmons and (the assumed) Julia Simmons, Dora Bunner and Phillipa Haymes. She can also pay for Mitzi, “a kind of lady cook help” (52). However, she is not rich enough to buy real pearls, for example. She mostly wears a choker of big false pearls in order to hide the scar from the operation.

They Do It with Mirrors (1952): Before his marriage to Carrie Louise, Lewis Serrocold is “the head of a very celebrated firm of chartered accountants”, which means that he is “well off” (26). To this has to be added half of Carrie Louise’s “considerable fortune” (153), which she has already distributed. The enormous house he lives in is Carrie Louise’s. The “College” (42), a building in which juveniles are kept, is also to be found on the premises. All this suggests that this couple is rich, which Walter Hudd thinks as well:

“They’re rich, these people. [...] They’re rolling in dough.” He deplores the lack of “upper-class servants” (64), which means that he thinks that they are upper-class. However, I believe that this is not the case. Lewis embezzles money for the retraining of criminals, about which he is obsessed. This suggests that he is middle-class, as the upper-class did not think about money like that. Nancy Mitford gives the example of the (fictional) ruined Fortinbras (starting in the 1930s and covering the war). Even though their situation keeps getting worse and they finally have to sell their estate, they do not work to earn money. Instead, Lord Fortinbras attends the City Council and the House of Lords and Lady Fortinbras does committee work (44-47). Even though their financial and social position cannot be compared to that of Lewis Serrocold, the Fortinbras illustrate “the typical aristocratic outlook on money” (47). This can be compared to Lewis’ philanthropy: he only spends time on the juveniles as “a Cause” and neglects all other duties just as the Fortinbras do. The difference is their attitude towards money: they do not embezzle money or work for it in order to support their good causes.

A Pocket Full of Rye (1953): Lancelot Fortescue has a wealthy father (see below: 2.2.1.1.), but as he is kicked out of the house, this means that he has to make it on his own in Africa. As the purpose of Lancelot’s coming to England is to get financial security, this means that he is not that successful. As Miss Marple puts it he only has a “small pittance he was living on, and which he had doubtless been supplementing in various dishonest ways” (300). His wife Pat is “the daughter of an Irish Peer” who was formerly married to “Lord Frederick Anstice” (27), and thus is a minor aristocrat. Lancelot says that he has “married into a class above” him (67), so I think it is likely that he has a middle-class status in Africa.

4.50 from Paddington (1957): The reader does not get much information about Dr Quimper’s social status. We only know that he drives a “battered Austin car” (98), which he keeps in his garage (168) and that he uses a “worn easy-chair” (147). Because the murders are

committed for money, I assume that Dr Quimper lacks it. Miss Marple says: “When he thought about taxation, and how much it cuts into income, he began thinking that it would be nice to have a good deal more capital” (219). The state his car and his chair are in indicate that he is upper-middle-class since he is less concerned with appearances than a lower-class person would be. Dr Quimper does not give a statement about his financial situation other than that he is glad that the state pays him, as opposed to the old times when a doctor had to take care of patients that could not pay for his services (114). This is an indication of lower-middle-class since he has more interest in being paid than in loyalty to local patients. He cannot be lower-class, as he then would not have had the opportunity to go to medical school. I would merge the upper- and lower-middle-class indications into middle-class.

The Mirror Crack'd from Side to Side (1962): Marina Gregg seems to be a very rich American actress. She buys the Gossington Hall and renovates it a lot, adding among other things “six new” bathrooms, “a pool”, and “picture windows” (19). According to Miss Marple, “it would have been much simpler, and probably cheaper, to have pulled it down and built a new house” (19). Apart from this, several servants are employed: an Italian butler, an Italian cook, a doctor, a gardener and two secretaries, who are “extremely well paid” (91). According to Mrs Bantry, it all amounts to “Snob status” (50). When it comes to Marina’s will, however, she has no fabulous sums to leave: “Her will benefits various people, but not to any large extent” (89). As she is an American actress who has come to England to act in a film, she is a foreigner. As she murders three people and tries to make the police believe that she is the intended victim, she definitely is untrustworthy. Based on the above information, it is clear that Marina aspires to an upper-middle-class lifestyle, so I give her this social status.

A Caribbean Mystery (1964): Tim Kendal stresses that he has given up his job and has put his money in the hotel, but Molly has paid the lion’s share (153). When Molly first met him, Tim was using another name. Molly’s parents forbade the relationship, as Tim was

“undesirable” and maybe even “delinquent” (153). He is very sympathetic towards Jackson, Mr Rafiel’s masseur, because he is sensitive to his social position (which might be lower-middle-class or lower-class). This might mean that Tim’s social status is close to Jackson’s. Moreover, he could make the hotel work if he wanted to but instead he chooses to marry a woman who will get “£50,000” (153). That woman is Esther, who is a “lower-middle-class” secretary (104). Assuming that he is attracted to people of his own class and allowing for his possible delinquent background, I would put Tim down as lower-middle-class.

At Bertram’s Hotel (1965): Elvira’s title –an Honourable– clearly indicates that she is upper-class. Also her education in Italy at Contessa Martinelli’s points to this. She is rich, although she cannot access the money that is held in trust yet: her lawyer estimates that she will come into “six or seven hundred thousand pounds” (63). She also drives her own car. Another indication of her social status is that her guardian Colonel Luscombe takes her to Bertram’s Hotel, which attracts the rich and the aristocracy: “the higher echelons of the clergy, dowager ladies of the aristocracy up from the country, girls on their way home for the holidays from expensive finishing schools” (1). The hotel is also described as “a well-bred, upper-class world in action” (82).

Nemesis (1971): Clotilde Bradbury-Scott lives in “The Old Manor House” that she and her sisters inherited from their uncle. The house, dating from 1780, now looks worn with age but “It was well proportioned, the furniture in it had been good furniture once” (69). When Miss Marple meets the sisters there she thinks that they are “well bred and gracious [...] ‘ladies’”, also called “Distressed gentlewomen” in former times. But she remarks that “Gentlewomen nowadays were not so liable to be distressed. They were aided by Government or by Societies or by a rich relation” (70). Yet the sisters lack money for the upkeep of the house and the garden. Their high social class is reflected in their sending Verity to Fallowfield, which is a “very fine” (138) and “famous girl’s school” (54) that is “fantastically

expensive” (131). Yet Clotilde and her sisters are not upper-class but upper-middle-class.

Charles Osborne writes: “It is interesting, incidentally, to contrast the Old Manor House and its one elderly servant with Styles Court of *The Mysterious Affair at Styles* fifty years earlier, buzzing with servants. The decline of the upper-middleclass [sic] in England had occurred during those fifty years” (346).

Sleeping Murder (1976): Dr Kennedy lives in a “bleak” (60) house without any central heating and he has one housekeeper. His previous house, however, had a tennis court.

Kennedy had taken care to bring up Helen well and to send her to “The right schools” (65).

Even though this is very little information to go on, it is still possible to deduce something from it. Kennedy cannot be lower-class as he then would not have been able to study to be a doctor and would probably not have taken care to select good schools for his sister. He is not upper-class either: he is not a lord or a peer, nor does he live in an estate or does he have aristocratic family connections. This only leaves middle-class.

I can now collect the results in the following manner:

Table 1

Murderers Allocated to Social Classes

Murderers	Upper-class	Upper-middle-class	Middle-class	Lower-middle-class	Lower-class
Mrs Anne Protheroe		1			
Lawrence Redding			1		
Josephine			1		

“Josie” Turner					
Mark Gaskell	1				
Mr Symmington		1			
Miss Charlotte Blacklock			1		
Lewis Serrocold			1		
Lancelot Fortescue			1		
Dr Quimper			1		
Marina Gregg		1			
Tim Kendal				1	
Elvira Blake	1				
Clotilde Bradbury- Scott		1			
Dr James Kennedy			1		
Total (14)	2	4	7	1	

Looking at these results, it can be seen clearly that most murderers come from the middle-classes: twelve characters out of fourteen can be assigned to these classes. Most of the murderers (seven) come from the middle-class, four come from the upper-middle-class and one comes from the lower-middle-class. This means that in the Miss Marple novels studied 86% of the characters are of the middle-classes, of which 29% come from the upper-middle-class, 50% from the middle-class and 7% from the lower-middle-class. With the exception of the lower-class, “anyone can be a killer in a Christie novel” (Bisbee and Herbert 68).

These results seem to correspond with the ones for Christie’s other detective novels, as Alison Light writes that “the unsettling implication” in her novels is that “‘it is the middle classes who are the murdering classes’” (97). Light thinks that this is because they represent “Real life” for Christie (83). Shaw and Vanacker have a different view: “Christie and the other Crime Club writers were concerned to stake out a different territory from Wallace, to mark out a middle-class enclave within detective fiction” (27). Another explanation might be that, being of the middle-class herself (critics do not agree whether this is upper-middle- or middle-class), she writes about the class which “she knew best” (Barnard 38). That Christie’s descriptions of the murderers make it possible to divide them not only into middle-class but also into upper-middle- and lower-middle-class illustrates that her “novels appear remarkably open-minded about that whole variety of lives which began to fall under the provenance of an expanding middle class” (Light 76).

An exception to this rule is that two murderers (14%) come from the upper-class. However, according to Charles Osborne, the rule “‘it is the middle classes who are the murdering classes’” can be expanded to include the upper-class: “Usually, it is only the crimes of the middle and upper-classes which commend themselves to her [Christie’s] investigators” (98). In any case, this low number of upper-class murderers seems to correspond with Christie’s other novels, as “Titles are rare in Mayhem Parva” (Barnard 39).

This means that Christie's murderers are statistically less likely to come from the lower-class, and indeed Shaw and Vanacker write that "the criminal [...] is rarely of the working-class" (20). This, according to Stephen Knight, is a convention in the novels of the Golden Age writers: "lower classes, especially professional criminals, play very minor roles" ("The Golden Age" 78). You can see that the Miss Marple novels abide by this tendency as no murderer has lower-class status. An explanation for this might be that "a servant or working-class culprit would make the detective story too political, too subversive of the class domination which was part and parcel of its ideology" (Shaw and Vanacker 20).

The conclusion that I draw from these results is that the Miss Marple novels follow the same rule as her other detective novels, namely that most murderers come from the middle-classes, some from the upper-class and few (in this case none) from the lower-classes. This means that you can indeed discern a pattern in the class allocation of the murderers. Light believes that "in her fictions one cannot predict the murderer by caste, except in being able to assume that it will not be the working-class person" (83). I have shown that this statement is not entirely correct as most murderers come from the middle-classes. However, this does not mean that you can safely assume that a middle-class character will be the murderer. Firstly, there is still some variation in upper-class and middle-class murderers. Secondly, other characters of course also play a role in the stories and might also come from the middle-classes. Some of these characters are the victims, and I therefore compare their social status to that of the murderers in section 2.2.1.

2.1.1.2. Murderers and their motives

Motives are inherent in detective fiction as most murderers kill for a reason. It would therefore be interesting to know what the murderers' motives are in the Marple novels and whether they differ by social class. In order to get an answer to this question, I give an

overview of the motives in the twelve Miss Marple novels studied and discuss them. Then I link the motives with the murderers' social classes and attempt to interpret the results.

The Murder at the Vicarage (1930): Anne Protheroe murders her husband because she is stuck in an unhappy marriage and falls in love with Lawrence Redding. After the murder, Anne plans to marry Lawrence (134). The motive can thus be called passion. A nice benefit is that Anne will inherit most of Colonel Protheroe's estate. This can be regarded as a second or sub-motive as "Money is always the motive of crime in detective fiction" (Moretti). Lawrence tries to murder Hawes because he and Anne would then certainly be cleared of the crime and avoid hanging. This third motive can be called fear of exposure.

The Body in the Library (1942): Mark kills Pamela and Josie kills Ruby because they stand to lose an important amount of their inheritance once Mr Jefferson has legally adopted Ruby Keene and made the £50,000 trust. Josie's attempt at murdering Mr Jefferson is also made for his money.

The Moving Finger (1943): Mr Symmington murders his wife because he is enamoured of the strikingly beautiful governess Elsie Holland. He wants to marry her, but that would cause a problem in a small town like Lymstock. He does not want to divorce his wife, because he wants to keep his "home, his children, [and] his respectability" (155). Murder is his only option. The motive can be called passion.

Because he is a lawyer, he knows that the police will suspect him. Therefore, he tries to distract attention by circulating poison-pen letters beforehand. Agnes, the slow-witted maid, was at home when the letter that allegedly killed Mrs Symmington should have arrived. Being on the lookout for her boyfriend, she saw nobody delivering any letter and telephones Burton's maid to make an appointment to talk this over. Mr Symmington probably overheard

her and kills her before she is able to go. The motive for the second murder is thus fear of exposure.

Miss Griffith is in love with Mr Symmington and hopes that she has a chance of marrying him after his wife's death. She decides to write a poison-pen letter to Elsie Holland to scare her away. When Symmington sees this letter, he guesses whom it is from. He plants the paper out of which he has cut letters in her house in order to frame her for his crimes. (I do not count this as a motive nor do I count her as a victim as Mr Symmington does not attempt to kill her. At best, she falls victim to fraud.)

Megan seemingly blackmails Mr Symmington, so he attempts to get rid of her as well, as she is too great a danger. This motive is also fear of exposure.

A Murder Is Announced (1950): The reason why Miss Blacklock kills Rudi Scherz is that she fears exposure as well as loss of money: if she is recognized as Charlotte instead of Letitia, she will lose the Goedler money. Dora Bunner is murdered because she knows too much: the motive is fear of exposure. Miss Murgatroyd is killed because she found out that Charlotte is the murderess. Charlotte attempts to kill Mitzi because Mitzi accuses her of being the murderess. The women are thus killed because Miss Blacklock fears to be exposed as the murderess of Rudi Scherz. Shaw and Vanacker call Charlotte's motive "greed" (82). However, I believe that the main motive is the fear of being exposed as impersonating her own sister, and that this is linked to "greed" for the Goedler money, which her sister would have received if she had not predeceased Mrs Goedler. (See also plot summary.)

They Do It with Mirrors (1952): Lewis Serrocold murders Christian Gulbrandsen, Ernie Gregg and Alex Restarick because he is afraid they will expose him. Gulbrandsen, however, is the only one who knows about the money angle. He confronts Lewis with it because he cares for Carrie Louise and realizes the consequences that an exposure of her husband will have. Lewis has already foreseen this and has brought Edgar to the house in

order to establish an alibi for the murder (277-78). Thanks to the police reconstruction, Alex knows that it does not take long to run into Christian's room and murder him. He realizes that everything was staged. This is obviously dangerous for Lewis. Ernie just boasted that he had been outside at the time. Everybody knows that he is a liar, but Lewis must have believed him.

A Pocket Full of Rye (1953): All three murders by Lancelot are inspired by money. Lancelot has married Pat and "wanted a respectable, settled life with her – nothing shifty. And that, from his point of view, meant having a lot of money" (300). When Rex refuses to take his son back, Lancelot decides to kill his father in order to save the firm from bankruptcy. He wants the Blackbird Mine, which looks like another wildcat scheme of his father's but Lancelot knows that the mine contains uranium and that this will make him incredibly rich. Preventing his father from wasting the firm's money means that there will be enough left to buy him out. This is the only way Lancelot can get his hands on money, as he has been cut out of his father's will.

The murder of Adele Fortescue ties in with this. She would get £100,000 if she survived Rex by one month, to be paid by the firm, possibly ruining it. It is thus a preventive murder, so that Lancelot still could get paid out. In between these two murders, Gladys Martin is killed. This is also preventive, as Lancelot could not risk her talking and giving him away. He had presented himself to her as Albert Evans at a holiday camp.

4.50 from Paddington (1957): Dr Quimper murders his first wife because she will not divorce him. That means that he will never be able to marry Emma Crackenthorpe. Dr Quimper poisons the Crackenthorpes with arsenic, and while nursing the family, he gives Alfred some more. He sends Harold some extra tablets, which are also poisoned. The motive for all the murders is money: Mr Crackenthorpe's father (Alfred and Harold's grandfather) put all his money in a trust. This trust pays his son an income but he cannot touch the money.

This is to be divided under his grandchildren when his son dies. By marrying Emma, Dr Quimper can get his hands on a good deal of money. The killing of other heirs means that his eventual share would increase (219-20).

The Mirror Crack'd from Side to Side (1962): Marina kills Heather out of revenge as she has destroyed her happiness: when Heather tells Marina about their previous meeting and her being ill at the time, Marina realizes that it was Heather who infected her with German measles. This affected her unborn child and made it handicapped. Marina wanted to have a child of her own but had difficulty in conceiving. Her handicapped child is her only biological child (she has three adopted children). She developed a grudge against the person who infected her, but whom she never knew until the party.

Ella has guessed that the murderer is Marina and threatens and blackmails her. She is in love with Jason Rudd, Marina's husband. Marina murders her, probably for fear of exposure. Giuseppe blackmails Marina and has got her to pay him £500. When he comes back from London, where he has put the sum on his bank account, she kills him. The murderess is thus guided by two motives: revenge for stolen happiness and fear of being exposed as the killer.

A Caribbean Mystery (1964): The Major correctly recognizes Tim Kendal as a serial killer who murders his wives. It has not been proven so far but two doctors have their suspicions. Kendal silences Major Palgrave because he is afraid of being exposed: the manner in which he killed his wives before has been the same, so the pattern will give him away when he kills Molly.

Victoria, the Caribbean maid, notices the bottle of tablets, which has not been in Palgrave's room before. She also knows that one of the other guests is missing the same bottle. She goes round asking questions and telling about it. Later, she realizes that she has actually seen Tim entering the Major's bungalow. This only occurs to her later as "it was

quite natural on various occasions for Tim Kendal to go into the guests' bungalows" (151).

Tim obviously has to silence her as well.

As said in the plot summary, Lucky is killed by mistake as Tim meant to murder his wife and Lucky looked like her. In this case, the motive is money: he wants to get rid of his wife in order to marry Esther, another guest, who will come into a lot of money. When he realises he has murdered the wrong woman, Tim has to act quickly. He gives Molly a poisoned drink, which will make it look like she has killed Lucky (due to her unstable mental condition) and took an overdose later. Tim finally wants to kill Molly because he fears exposure:

He must have felt quite desperate. Here was Molly alive and wandering about. And the story he'd circulated so carefully about her mental condition wouldn't stand up for a moment once she got into the hands of competent mental specialists. And once she told her damning story of his having asked her to meet him at the creek, where would Tim Kendal be? He'd only one hope-to finish off Molly as quickly as possible. (156)

Tim is thus guided by two motives: money and fear of exposure.

At Bertram's Hotel (1965): Michael Gorman has been married to Bess Sedgwick, which means that Bess' other marriages were all bigamous. Her daughter Elvira fears that she will not inherit her father's money, as his marriage to Bess was de facto illegal. She kills Gorman because she needs the inheritance. Elvira is in love with Ladislaus Malinowski and wants to buy his love: "She knew that with the money she'd get him, and without the money she'd lose him" (179). Michael is thus killed for both passion and money. Bess pretends to be the killer and commits suicide to save her daughter. Her death is provoked by Elvira's passion and need of money.

Nemesis (1971): Clotilde Bradbury-Scott adopts Verity Hunt when her parents, who were Clotilde's friends, were killed in an airplane accident. She treats Verity as a daughter and comes to love her very much. When Verity falls in love with Michael, Clotilde considers him to be a bad match because he is a criminal. Moreover, she loves Verity that much, that she does not want to lose her to anyone, certainly not to such an undesirable young man as Michael. She thus kills Verity for love. According to Charles Osborne, this is not motherly love but "lesbian" love (346), which means that the motive is passion.

Clotilde lures Nora Broad away to a deserted place, kills her, beats her face in and leaves her there. When Nora's body is found, it is unrecognizable and Clotilde identifies it as Verity. Miss Marple thinks that she killed her because she wanted Michael to be convicted of the murder (201). Thus the motive is revenge.

The murder of Miss Temple is committed for fear of being exposed. Miss Temple is going to Archdeacon Brabazon to talk about Verity with him. Brabazon, who knew Verity when she was little, agreed to marry her and Michael in secret. Miss Temple knew Verity as a schoolgirl. If they put their heads together, they might arrive at the truth, which is too dangerous for Clotilde.

Clotilde tries to poison Miss Marple first with coffee, then with hot milk. At night, she goes up to Miss Marple's room to check whether the poisoned milk has worked. When she sees that Miss Marple is alive and when she hears that Miss Marple has found out everything, she advances threateningly towards her bed with the intention of killing her. The motive is of course fear of exposure: Miss Marple knows too much.

Sleeping Murder (1976): Dr Kennedy has to take care of his much younger half-sister Helen, which actually means that he has to bring her up. He falls in love with her and does everything to prevent her from meeting other men. Helen finally runs away and meets Kelvin Halliday. They decide to get married and then go to Dillmouth to break the news to Dr

Kennedy. Kennedy acts as if he approves of the marriage. Helen finally understands that he loves her and wants to get away from him. When Kennedy realizes that Helen is going to escape him, he strangles her in the hall. The motive can thus be classified as passion.

Kennedy has been drugging Kelvin in order to break down his health. He makes Kelvin believe he killed Helen and advises him to go to a mental home. Kelvin commits suicide in the mental home because he cannot live with the thought of having killed Helen. His death can thus be seen as a delayed murder by Kennedy and the motive is Kennedy's love for Helen.

Kennedy kills Léonie because she has seen him digging a grave for Helen at night. He gives her hush money and tells her to return to Switzerland. There she takes an overdose of sleeping pills, which Kennedy has given her. The motive is thus fear of exposure.

When Lily writes to ask Kennedy's advice about the advertisement, she also mentions that she knows that Helen is killed because the wrong clothes were gone; and because of her seeing a certain car in the neighbourhood, she does no longer believe that it was Kelvin who killed Helen. Kennedy wrongly thinks that she is trying to blackmail him. He proposes to meet her in a wood nearby and strangles her there. The motive is thus fear of exposure.

Gwenda and Giles' investigation is dangerous for Kennedy, as they are getting closer even though they have not thought of him as the murderer. He poisons their brandy but Mrs Cocker is the first one to drink it. Her near death is an accident, but the reason why the brandy is poisoned is that Kennedy fears that he will be exposed soon. When Gwenda is upstairs, wearing surgical gloves with which she did the dishes, and Kennedy enters, he calls out to her "Is that you, Gwennie? I can't see your face ... My eyes are dazzled -" (211). These words and his voice remind Gwenda of the lines from *The Duchess of Malfi* and her own gloved hands remind her of the killer's hands she saw as a child. She screams as she realizes that he

is the murderer. He comes up the stairs and wants to strangle her. The motive is thus fear of exposure.

Table 2

The Murderers' Motives by Novel

Novel	Motive
The Murder at the Vicarage	Fear of exposure/ money/ passion
The Body in the Library	Money
The Moving Finger	Fear of exposure/ passion
A Murder Is Announced	Fear of exposure/ money
They Do It with Mirrors	Fear of exposure
A Pocket Full of Rye	Money
4.50 from Paddington	Money
The Mirror Crack'd from Side to Side	Fear of exposure/ revenge
A Caribbean Mystery	Fear of exposure/ money
At Bertram's Hotel	Money/ passion
Nemesis	Fear of exposure/ revenge/passion

Sleeping Murder	Fear of exposure/ passion
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A first remark that I can make is that the murderers' motives are relatively clear in the Miss Marple novels. An explanation for this can be found in Malmgren: he divides "murder fiction" (115) into three categories and sees Agatha Christie as a representative of the category of "mystery fiction" (118). In this category, "crime is a function of (conventional) motive. The conventions of mystery dictate that its world be pre-eminently rational and its characters psychologically transparent" (121). In Christie's novels, Miss Marple usually judges the murderers and explains their motives at the end of the novel, even if the reader has probably deduced these earlier on. Thus the murderers and their motives are made "psychologically transparent" at the end of the novel.

As for the motives themselves, it can be seen that Christie only uses four different motives in the Miss Marple novels studied: fear of exposure, passion, money and revenge. These seem to correspond with the motives used in her other novels as Priestman writes on the basis of "ten representative texts" that "money, fear of exposure, and sexual jealousy" are the "central motives" in Christie's writing, and that a "wider sample of novels" would include "revenge [...] a perverted sense of justice [...] [and] indiscriminate malice" as well (*Detective Fiction and Literature* 154-55). Seen from a wider perspective, the four motives used in the Miss Marple novels correspond with two out of the four categories of motives generally used in crime fiction: "practical motives" and "emotional satisfaction". The first category comprises "greed (murder for gain) and self-protection (elimination of a threat)", which in the novels studied corresponds with money and fear of exposure. The other category comprises "revenge, envy, and jealousy, plus love-the desire to possess or protect someone", which corresponds with the motives of revenge and passion (Rahn 296). Christie's restricted use of

motives agrees with the conventions of “mystery fiction” as its “crimes [...] are [...] the product of a limited number of self-evident motives” (Malmgren 119). It can, however, also be explained in the following manner: “In real life, [...] murders are sometimes committed for the most trivial motives; but in the detective-story world, [...] this most serious of crimes cannot be committed save for the most serious motives” (Hare 70). The four motives in the Miss Marple novels are indeed “most serious” and may be the primary ones, ‘the most serious motives’.

Another view of the matter shows that Christie can create variation with a restricted number of motives. In most of the Miss Marple novels studied (67%), the four motives are combined, in others (33%) the murderer is guided by only one. In these twelve novels, eight possibilities occur:

- 1) money (25%)
- 2) fear of exposure and money (16.7%)
- 3) fear of exposure and passion (16.7%)
- 4) fear of exposure and revenge (8.3%)
- 5) fear of exposure, revenge and passion (8.3%)
- 6) fear of exposure, money and passion (8.3%)
- 7) fear of exposure (8.3%)
- 8) money and passion (8.3%)

Most murders are committed because the murderer wants money. Otherwise, the murderer will kill because he fears exposure, which might or might not be combined with another motive. The motives with which fear of exposure is combined most are money and passion.

This suggests that both patterning and variation is going on in the Miss Marple novels.

Chances are high that the murders will occur for motives one to three (patterning) but motives four to eight also occur (variation). The reader cannot be entirely sure beforehand what the

motive or motives will be by novel as the pattern that Christie uses still varies from novel to novel.

In order to explore which motives might be typical for a certain social class of murderers, I combine table 1 and table 2. I use the four separate motives instead of the combinations of motives mentioned above, as it is my intention to show the prevalence of motives in a complex pattern of murder events.

Table 3

The Murderers' Motives by Social Class: Linking Table 1 to Table 2

Motives/ social class	Upper- class	Upper- middle- class	Middle- class	Lower- middle- class	Lower- class
Passion	1	3	1		
Fear of exposure		3	4	1	
Money	2	1	4	1	
Revenge		2			
Total (23)	3	9	9	2	

Now it is easy to see that the upper-class murders for passion and money. The upper-middle-class on the other hand murders for all motives: passion, fear of exposure, money and revenge. The middle-class kills for all motives except revenge. The lower-middle-class murders for fear of exposure and money. As no murderers have lower-class status, no murders occur in this class. This information enables me to conclude that yet again there is some patterning going on in the Miss Marple novels. The upper-class and lower-middle-class

murderers kill for only two reasons, of which they share one (money). The upper-middle-class and middle-class murderers, however, kill for more varied reasons, which makes it hard to recognize a pattern in this case. Still, they have only four motives to choose from. It would seem as though an attentive reader can be on the lookout for these four motives and try to deduce the social class of the murderer from their occurrence. However, Christie does not make it that easy. For example, the motive of money, which both the upper-class and the lower-middle-class share, also occurs in the other two classes. Only the motive of revenge is used by one specific class (upper-middle-class). This means that even though Christie only uses four motives and even though they are patterned to an extent, she still creates variation, which makes it nearly impossible to deduce the murderers' social class from the motives.

If I go back to the aim that started this section about the murderers' social class off, namely to investigate whether variation occurs in the murderers' social status and in the motives used by the different social classes of murderers, then the answer has to be that both variation and patterning occurs. The distribution of murderers among the social classes is clearly patterned as an overwhelming majority originates from the middle-classes. The allocation of motives to a social class of murderers, on the other hand, is varied as no exact parallels can be established for the motives the social classes kill for and as only one out of the four motives can be assigned to a specific social class.

2.1.2. Sex of the characters

In this section, I look at how Christie's male and female murderers (in table 4) come from different social classes and if they use different motives. Shaw and Vanacker's suspicion that sex is an important factor is the reason for this examination: "The implication for a reader of a Marple novel is that differences of class and wealth (*but perhaps not age and sex*) count

for little” (emphasis added) (74). In the second chapter, I examine the victims’ sex for the same reason.

Table 4

The Sex of the Murderers

Murderers	Male	Female
Mrs Anne Protheroe		1
Lawrence Redding	1	
Josephine “Josie” Turner		1
Mark Gaskell	1	
Mr Symmington	1	
Miss Charlotte Blacklock		1
Lewis Serrocold	1	
Lancelot Fortescue	1	
Dr Quimper	1	
Marina		1

Gregg		
Tim Kendal	1	
Elvira Blake		1
Clotilde Bradbury- Scott		1
Dr James Kennedy	1	
Total (14)	8	6

The male murderers are slightly in the majority: out of fourteen murderers, eight are male and six are female. This means that in the Miss Marple novels, 57% of murderers are male and 43% are female. The number of male and female murderers is thus more or less even. Because of this, the patterning is almost non-existent: there are more male murderers but their number is relative. This evidence suggests that the reader will not be able to guess beforehand which sex the murderer will be, which means that Christie uses enough variation. I will compare these numbers to those for the victims in chapter 2.2.2. This statement is still correct if you look at the number of male and female murderers per novel. Shaw and Vanacker note that “of the Marple novels, half have women as a murderer.” This is correct as out of the twelve novels, six have female murderers. The reason why there are still more male murderers is that the female murderers operate “either alone [...] or as one of a murderous partnership” (81). These “murderous partnership[s]” occur in two novels out of the six in which these female murderers play a role, which explains the extra two male murderers.

2.1.2.1. Allocation of male and female murderers to social classes

In order to investigate if male and female murderers come from different social classes, I add table 4 to table 1.

Table 5

Male and Female Murderers by Social Class: Linking Table 4 to Table 1

Sex/ social class	Upper-class	Upper-middle-class	Middle-class	Lower-middle-class	Lower-class
Male	1	1	5	1	
Female	1	3	2		
Total (14)	2	4	7	1	

Out of fourteen characters, both one male and one female murderer come from the upper-class. In the upper-middle-class, one male murderer and three female murderers occur. In the middle-class, five men outnumber two women. Only one male murderer originates from the lower-middle-class. As said in 2.1.1.1., no murderers can be allocated to the lower-class. In other words, 7.1% male and 7.1% female murderers come from the upper-class. 7.1% male murderers come from the upper-middle-class, whereas 21.4% female murderers are of this class. In the middle-class, male murderers (35.7%) outnumber the women (14.3%). One male murderer in the lower-middle-class equals 7.1%.

The conclusion that I draw from this is that male and female murderers do not seem to come from different social classes. They are equally divided among the upper-class, less so among the upper-middle-class and the middle-class. Only the lower-middle-class is all-male. Patterning can only be seen in that no murderers come from the lower-class and that no female murderers come from the lower-middle-class. This suggests that Christie creates

enough variation in the allocation of male and female murderers to social classes so that it is of no use to the reader to focus on either social class or sex in order to predict the murderer.

2.1.2.2. Male and female murderers' motives

Based on my findings in 2.1.1.2., I will examine whether the motives differ for male and female murderers or not. This means that I will investigate which of the four motives are typical for male and female murderers. In order to do this, I will draw a table based on table 3 and table 4.

Table 6

Murderers' Motives by Sex

Motives/sex	Male	Female
Passion	3	3
Fear of exposure	5	4
Money	5	4
Revenge		2
Total (26)	13	13

Both men and women use the same total amount of motives (thirteen each). This can of course be explained by the (relatively) equal amount of male and female murderers. The motive of passion guides three men and three women, fear of exposure guides five men and four women, money is a motive for five men and four women and revenge is an all-female motive for two women. Looking at the motives themselves, all motives except one are used by both sexes. This means that both patterning and variation is going on in this case.

Patterning in the sense that one motive out of four (revenge) is an all-female motive and

variation in the sense that three motives out of four (passion, fear of exposure and money) are used by both men and women. Disregarding the motive of revenge, the reader cannot predict whether the murderer will be male or female when he has recognized the motive for the crime.

The conclusion for this section is that variation occurs with regard to the murderers' sex. The number of male and female murderers is nearly even, both sexes come from the same social classes (one class excepted) and they all use the same motives (one motive excepted).

The overall conclusion that I can draw for this first chapter is that with regard to the murderers in the Miss Marple novels, Agatha Christie uses both patterning and variation to a certain extent. The distribution of murderers among the social classes is patterned whereas the use of motives per social class contains more variation. Patterning disappears in the same categories when one focuses on the murderers' sex.

2.2. The victims

In this chapter, I examine the victims in the Miss Marple novels. As is the case for the murderers in 2.1., this chapter consists of two main topics: the victims' social class and their sex.

2.2.1. Social class

In 2.2.1.1., I determine the victims' social status, for which I first give an overview of my motivations for the classification. After this, I draw a table to show the results and I discuss them. I then compare the results to those of the murderers. In the table, I indicate

which characters are not killed but suffer from an attempt to kill them. Nevertheless, they are still victims and appear in the table. In the previous chapter I showed that murderers kill for specific motives. In 2.2.1.2., I examine which social class of victims is killed for which motive in order to see whether two or more classes of victims are killed for the same motives or not.

2.2.1.1. Allocation of the victims to social classes

In determining the social status of the victims, the same criteria and method are used as in 2.1.1.1. As is the case in the previous chapter, I include foreigners in the class discussion.

The Murder at the Vicarage (1930): Colonel Protheroe is a rich man: he keeps several servants (among others a butler, a parlourmaid and a kitchenmaid), which contrasts with, for example, the households of Miss Marple and the vicar: they have one maid each. He has a chauffeur and at least one car as Lettice asks the chauffeur for a particular car (the Fiat) (96). This is an important clue as cars were very expensive at the time and would only be owned by rich people. Another indication is the will Protheroe has made. Anne says: “Lucius was very well off, you know. He left things pretty equally divided between me and Lettice. Old Hall goes to me, but Lettice is to be allowed to choose enough furniture to furnish a small house, and she is left a separate sum for the purpose of buying one, so as to even things up” (135). The house, which is described as having two entrances (96), also contains valuable property, which the person pretending to be Dr. Stone attempts to steal: “Colonel Protheroe’s trencher salts, and the Charles II tazza” (142). According to the vicar’s wife, Protheroe’s silver is very expensive. It seems as though he lives in an upper-class environment but because he has no title, does not behave with the manners of the upper-class, and is ex-army (who are rarely

from the true aristocracy), he cannot be regarded as such. I therefore believe he is upper-middle-class.

Hawes is a curate who lives in a boarding house where he has a bedroom and a living room. He has got sleeping sickness, which causes headaches and makes him nervous. The sleeping sickness indicates that he has come home from Africa, where he probably worked as a missionary. This, and the place he is staying at, indicates that he is not very wealthy. He probably is middle-class.

The Body in the Library (1942): Pamela Reeves is a Girl Guide who is “very fond of going to Woolworth’s” (130). She lives together with her parents in “Braeside”, which is described as a “Neat little villa, nice garden of about an acre and a half. The sort of place that had been built fairly freely all over the countryside in the last twenty years.” Because of this, the further description “Retired Army men, retired Civil Servants – that type. [...] Spent as much money as they could afford on their children’s education,” (129) and since money is a problem and the house is not large I would say that she is lower-middle-class.

Ruby Keene is an eighteen-year-old “training for a dancer” (40). The hotel manager remarks that she is “cheap in style” (59). Her social status can be determined on the basis of the information that Mr Jefferson gives to the police: “She chattered on about her life and her experiences – in pantomime, with touring companies, with Mum and Dad as a child in cheap lodgings. [...] Not a lady [...] nor [...] ‘lady-like’” (76). He is convinced that “With education and polishing, Ruby Keene could have taken her place anywhere” (77). This, to me, is reminiscent of Shaw’s *Pygmalion* (written in 1912) and I would therefore classify her as lower-class. This is further supported by Edwards, Mr Jefferson’s valet, who calls her “a common little piece” (177).

Mr Jefferson is, according to the hotel manager, “very well off”(62) and spends a lot of money in the hotel. Jefferson confirms this himself when he relates how he made a lot of

money after the accident (79). Based on the £50,000 he will leave Ruby and the £5000 to £10,000 he intends to leave to Adelaide and Mark (79), I am convinced that he is upper-class.

The Moving Finger (1943): If Mrs Symmington was not upper-middle-class before her marriage, she became it by marriage: “In a period when they mostly did not work outside the home, the class position of middle-class women was still largely determined by their fathers or husbands” (Humble 59). For a discussion of her upper-middle-class status, see the discussion of Mr Symmington’s social position in 2.1.1.1.

Agnes Woddell is a young woman who was raised in an orphanage called “St. Clotilde’s Home” (110). After having worked for the Bartons (who employed her from the age of sixteen), she currently works for the Symmingtons. She has a boyfriend, “young Rendell from the fish shop” (94). Emily Barton, her first employer, describes her as being “raw” but “most teachable” (110). The orphanage indicates that Agnes is lower-class.

Miss Griffith is also a victim in the sense that Mr Symmington tries to frame her for his murders and that her reputation suffers from this. However, she does not get killed nor is she threatened with death. At best, she falls victim to fraud. I do not incorporate her in the list of victims as all other victims are killed or the murderer attempts to kill them.

Because Megan Hunter is Mr Symmington’s stepdaughter, living with the family means that she adopts their upper-middle-class status (see 2.1.1.1.). She is given an allowance of £40 a year with which she cannot do much (40). However, her prospects will change when she comes of age because she will then inherit her grandmother’s money (150). It is assumed that this will be enough income for her not to have to work (58-59).

A Murder Is Announced (1950): Rudi Scherz works as a receptionist and among other things “charged up certain items which didn’t appear in the hotel records, and [...] pocketed the difference when the bill was paid” (40). Miss Marple suspects that “the money Rudi Scherz used to replace his earlier defalcations [this means thefts] at the hotel may have come

from Charlotte Blacklock” (220). However, this is not his first series of crimes: he has got a Swiss criminal record. According to Miss Marple, he steals in order to keep “himself going in ready money so that he can dress well, and take a girl about” (81). There is evidence that he lies: he tells Myrna Harris, the girl he goes out with, “about how rich his people were in Switzerland – and how important”, but she suspects that this is not true: “a lot of stories he used to tell me were so much hot air” (42). Because of his series of criminal activities (full account on page 89) and therefore crooked nature, I believe that Myrna is right in calling him a liar. Rudi originates from Switzerland and is thus a foreigner who is not to be trusted: “you never know where you are with foreigners” (41). Based on all of this information, I believe that his honorary class status is lower-class.

Dora Bunner has come to live with Miss Blacklock because she is needy and ill. She cannot support herself: “She was living in one room, trying to subsist on her old age pension. She endeavoured to do needlework, but her fingers were stiff with rheumatism” (20-21). She might be of the same class as Miss Blacklock but just unlucky in life. I believe that she is middle-class.

Miss Murgatroyd lives together with Miss Hinchliffe “at Boulders, the picturesque three cottages knocked into one” (13). As there is no more information about her social status to be found, I am inclined to believe that she is middle-class: there is no mention of her being needy or very rich. I think this claim can be supported by the place she lives in: even if the converting of the cottages had been done before the two ladies moved in, they would have to pay a substantial amount of money to buy it. This would be manageable by splitting the cost.

Mitzi is a “Mittel European” (108) refugee⁷ who, according to her own statement, has seen her entire family being murdered in Europe. She now works as a cook for Miss Blacklock, a position she resents very much as she was higher up in her own country. She says she has had “expensive university education” (58). However, in England her social

position is reduced to lower-class as she has to work as a servant and does not belong anywhere else. She is an untrustworthy foreigner who is regularly accused of lying (103).

They Do It with Mirrors (1952): Christian Gulbrandsen is the eldest of the late Eric Gulbrandsen's three sons. Carrie Louise married the extremely wealthy Eric when all his sons were already adults. According to Serrocold, Christian is "a very wealthy man" (142). This is confirmed by Alex Restarick, who uses the fact that Christian has "quite a collection [...] of Thorwaldsen's statuary" to point out that he is rich (177). Presumably, he would also have inherited his father's money – "a fortune so colossal that really philanthropy had been the only solution to the disposal of it," (13)- which makes him upper-class. Christian's father is Scandinavian; the origins of his mother are not given.

Alex Restarick is not as rich as Christian –otherwise he would not have made the above remark adding "My God, these rich men!" (177)- but Carrie Louise supports his work. Ruth presumes that his father married Carrie Louise for her money. Inspector Curry thinks it is possible that Alex likes "living soft" (179). Given this and the people he associates with, he is probably middle-class. His mother is Russian and his surname also suggests that his father is foreign.

Ernie Gregg is one of the juveniles who are being trained at the centre. He is being kept there because he picks locks. Because of his criminal activities and his being kept at the centre, it is likely that he is lower-class. This claim might be supported by the dialect he speaks (cf p 225-27, another juvenile delinquent also speaks dialect on pages 258-59).

A Pocket Full of Rye (1953): Rex Fortescue is a wealthy man: Yewtree Lodge actually is "a mansion" (40) in Baydon Heath, which is "almost entirely inhabited by rich city men" (24). This latter statement already indicates that he is not upper-class. The house has "well-kept grounds" (233) as well as among other things a smoking-room, a library with a "richly furnished interior décor" (138), a drawing-room and a guest room. Bedrooms have a dressing-

room, a bath and a sitting-room. Rex also pays for a butler, a cook, a housekeeper, a parlourmaid, a housemaid, three gardeners and outside help. Mrs Fortescue drives a “Rolls Bentley sports model coupé” (71). Miss Dove proves that he is wealthy when she says: “I work only for the extremely rich who will pay anything to be comfortable” (49). The money he needs to pay for all this is not entirely got by honest means. He has “connections with the black market” and boasts about swindling people but manages to stay “just within the law”. Inspector Neele calls him a “financial genius” who manages to fool the “Inland Revenue” that “have been after him for a long time” (35). This is yet another indication that he cannot be upper-class. He is proud of his son Lancelot marrying into the aristocracy and he makes sure that “No expense [is] spared” (233). His money would make him upper-middle-class, but his attitudes and behaviour bring him down to middle-class.

Adele Fortescue is Rex’ “glamorous and expensive” second wife (8). Before the marriage, she worked as a “manicurist” and was only interested in Rex because of his money (50). She cheats on her husband with Vivian Dubois, “the type that specialized in the young wives of rich and elderly men” (72). Percival’s wife describes her as “man-mad” and spending a good deal of money (240). Because of her manicurist background, she is lower-class before the marriage. By marrying Rex, she becomes middle-class even though she does not live up to it.

The “credulous” Gladys Martin was raised in an orphanage called St Faith’s (144). Miss Marple employed and trained her when she was seventeen. When Inspector Neele goes through her possessions, he notices that she does not have much of good quality. Because she is an orphan and works as a maid (she also worked in cafés), I would classify Gladys as lower-class.

4.50 from Paddington (1957): Mrs McGillicuddy sees Mrs Quimper on the train but because she is being strangled it is difficult for her to describe the woman exactly. All she can

say is that the woman is dressed in “a fur coat of some kind, a palish fur” (sic), that she has “No hat” (a sign of lower-class since a lady would always have a hat), and that “Her hair was blonde” (13-14). It turns out that the “fur coat is a cheap one” (90). When Lucy is hunting for evidence at the Rutherford Hall, she finds a bit of the coat in a thorn bush and a “small cheap enamelled” powder compact belonging to the woman (42). The emphasis on her belongings being cheap rules out upper- and upper-middle-class. I therefore believe that she is middle-class. Based on her underwear, the police think that she is a foreigner (61) and that she might be a Frenchwoman (69, see also 90-91).

Alfred Crackenthorpe is the “black-sheep” (39) of the family because he gets into shady deals. He asks Lucy to help him with “by-passing [...] the law” (117). His appearance is “superficially smart” (81): he tries to look important in cheap clothes. He can certainly use the capital that will come his way when his father dies as he “is almost incessantly in low water. Occasionally he is very flush of money for a short time – but it soon goes” (128). According to his brother Harold, he belongs to the “small-time speculators” who will never have a “broad outlook” (196). He lives in a “built-in” flat in a “big modern building”. The flat is “rented furnished” (133). He looks like an unfortunate middle-class man. If we assume that his father is correct about their heritage (he claims that they descend from kings before the Normans such as “Edward the Confessor” and “Ethelred the Unready” [101-02]) this certainly safeguards against lower-class. However, this is a ludicrous claim and therefore an indicator of a lower social status since they are making desperate claims to an impossible pre-medieval royalty. As Alfred has a hard time making money and is connected with criminal activities, I believe that he is middle-class.

Harold Crackenthorpe has been more fortunate than his brother: he is married to the daughter of an earl (38). He married her purely for her connections and the benefit he and his children would derive from that (but he has not succeeded in having any children) (196-97).

He looks very prosperous: everything in his office looks very expensive and so does he. But he expects that his business will crash soon, which is due to his undertaking “undesirable ventures” (146). Only his grandfather’s money can help him overcome this. He is like his brother Alfred: he pretends to be successful. Only he gets away with it: he is “the perfect picture of a City gentleman and a director of important companies.” At home, he has two servants. He drives a “Humber Hawk” (132), for which he rents a garage. Because of his fortunate marriage, I would classify him as an upper-middle-class man. His firm is on the brink of a crash now, but he has been successful before, otherwise he could not afford all the expenses. He is clearly better off than Alfred, which is why I believe he is upper-middle-class instead of just middle-class.

The Mirror Crack’d from Side to Side (1962): Heather Badcock lives at “Arlington Close” (54) in “the Development”, a “housing estate” (41) that is fairly new in St. Mary Mead. She works for the St. John’s Ambulance Corps and met Marina in Bermuda when “there was a big show in aid of” the Corps (15). She is married to Marina’s first husband, who left America and assumed another name after the divorce. According to Chief-Inspector Craddock, “She had no money to speak of” (65). I think that Heather is an ordinary middle-class woman.

Ella Zielinsky is Jason Rudd’s “extremely competent and efficient” (105) secretary but also has to “look after Miss Gregg’s social life, her public and private engagements, and to supervise in some degree the running of the house” (91). She probably has come over from America with Marina and the rest of the entourage. In any case, the police say that “She is a stranger in this country [meaning England]” (161). Her blackmailing of Marina makes her untrustworthy. As she is a secretary, I would put her down as lower-middle-class.

Giuseppe is an Italian butler. He has relatives in London, whom he claims to visit while he actually deposits the £500 he got from Marina by blackmailing her. His blackmailing makes him an untrustworthy foreigner. As he is a servant, he is lower-class.

A Caribbean Mystery (1964): Major Palgrave bores people with stories of animals he has shot when he lived in Kenya and of murderers he has known. He heard the murder story in a club, which means that he lives in or comes from England. Miss Marple believes that he lives in London. As there is no mention of somebody benefiting from the Major's death financially, this might mean that he is not rich. Yet, he has to have enough money to be able to take a vacation in the Caribbean. As he is a military man and seems not to have any relations to boast of in his stories, I believe this prevents him from being upper-class. His going to a club means that he is not lower-class either. I therefore assume that he is middle-class.

Victoria Johnson is a "St. Honoré girl" (36), who lives together with and has children by a Caribbean man but is not married to him. As she tries to get money out of the Major's death, it seems she is untrustworthy. However, according to Lieutenant Weston, she does not see this as blackmail: "Payment for being discreet isn't thought of as blackmail" (76, see also 92). She works at the hotel as a maid, which makes her lower-class.

Lucky Dyson is a Californian woman of about forty, whose maiden name was Miss Greatorax. "Lucky" is not her real name; it is a pet name her husband Gregory invented. She is the "cousin of his first wife" (52), whom she murdered in order to marry Gregory. I do not treat her as a murderer as that murder is not part of Miss Marple's investigation and is not known to the police. Gregory Dyson is "a very rich man" because his first wife "left [him] a lot of money" (66), which means that Lucky is not that badly off. She can also spend a holiday of three months in the Caribbean. On the other hand, she cannot be extremely rich, as St. Honoré does not attract "the flashy, ultra-rich set" (111). I believe she is middle-class.

Molly Kendal is the proprietress of the hotel. I have established in 2.1.1.1. that Tim is lower-middle-class. As Molly is higher in status (the hotel is bought mainly with her money and her parents did not approve of the match) I would say that she is middle-class. I do not believe that she is upper-middle-class, as she has used all her money for buying the hotel and has to work hard now to succeed (which she can do: the Kendals were already managing well). What is more, the Kendals live in a bungalow, which does not distinguish them from other guests (all guests have their own bungalow). When Jackson is caught red-handed in their bathroom, he remarks that Molly has not got that many “toilet preparations” (132). This might mean that she has not got that much money left to spend. The scarf she wears also indicates this: she has bought it at the shop at the hotel.

At Bertram's Hotel (1965): Michael Gorman is an Irish ex-army man who likes a gamble. Chief Inspector Davy sums him up like this: “A bit run to seed. [...] A bit shifty? Drinks too much” (99-100). His untrustworthy character was shown when he accepted money from Bess' parents to set her free. He also seems not to be the person he appears to be: Bess says that “The first twenty-four hours [of the marriage] were enough to disillusion me. He drank and he was coarse and brutal” (167). He now works as a commissionaire at the hotel. I believe he is lower-class because of his drinking, his gambling and his job as a commissionaire. This is also supported by his behaviour during his marriage to Bess.

Lady Sedgwick leads a dangerous life: “Running into danger has become a kind of habit with me. No, I wouldn't say habit. More an addiction. Like a drug” (35). She is consequently never out of the media. She runs the crime syndicate that operates from Bertram's Hotel and she is a shareholder of the Hoffmans who “are the ones behind Bertram's Hotel-financially” (120). She is not that badly off: “She has plenty of money from her American husband. Enough, anyway” (155). She owns the same type of racing car as Ladislaus Malinowski: a “Mercedes-Otto car” (107). Her title indicates that she is upper-class.

I treat her as a victim as her death was –unconsciously- instigated by Elvira: “She chose death for herself, at the price of her daughter going free” (180).

Nemesis (1971): It is impossible to assess what social class Verity Hunt belonged to when she was living with her parents. It is only mentioned that her parents were friends of Clotilde’s. One might assume that Clotilde would have formed a friendship with people of the same social milieu. By being adopted, Verity became Clotilde’s daughter. I would therefore give Verity Clotilde’s upper-middle-class status (see 2.1.1.1.). In the novel, Verity’s social status is not problematic in relation to that of the three sisters. The only trouble arises when she wants to marry Michael Rafiel, who is felt to be no match for the girl. This is because he has a criminal reputation, but one might also assume that, even though Michael has a wealthy father whom the sisters “knew [...] very well” (138) through Michael’s mother, he is beneath Verity in social class as well.

Nora Broad’s promiscuous reputation (and ensuing pregnancy) is a pointer to lower-class. She is a “foolish girl” (155) and not a good student: “She was idle and she wasn’t too clever at her books either” (158). Clotilde describes her as “a silly little tramp, an adolescent tart” (200).

Miss Elizabeth Temple is the “famous” (63) and “retired Headmistress” (54) of Fallowfield. She “radiates integrity” (55) and “is a woman of perception,” (120) who “occupied a prominent position in the educational world” (121). She is a great scholar, who knows everything about education and whose power has not diminished since she retired. What we can deduce is that she definitely is not lower-class as she then would not have been able to get a teaching diploma. This means that she has to be at least middle-class. It is likely that she is a bit higher up the social scale as she has worked in a school that is prestigious and expensive. I would therefore put her down as upper-middle-class.

Miss Marple, who has to rely on financial aid from her nephew Raymond West, is according to Nadel-Klein, “a ‘genteel’ woman” (114). This means that she belongs to a good social class. I agree with Monika Mueller that she is “upper-middle-class” (129). Evidence can be found in Anne Hart’s *The Life and Times of Miss Jane Marple*⁸. Miss Marple and her sister “seem to have led the sort of strict, protected, by governesses controlled life that we know from the first chapters of so many Victorian autobiographies” (36). It is not clear who her parents were but Hart deduces that she probably was “the daughter of a canon, or the dean of a cathedral” (37). Hart says about her mother and grandmother that they “undertook to familiarize Miss Marple from an early age with the obligations and mysteries of being a lady” (37-38). Her education was completed by sending her “to a boarding school for girls in Florence” (40). When she is an adult, Miss Marple lives in a “small but attractive Victorian house” (42), “which is sometimes called a small old-fashioned villa” (89). In earlier times, she was able to pay for “maidservants” but nowadays she has to make do with a “housekeeper” (89-90) (due to the disappearance of maidservants over time).

Sleeping Murder (1976): Helen Kennedy and Kelvin Halliday lived in the same house Gwenda and Giles live in later. It was then called “St Catherine’s” (62). (For a description of the house, see the discussion of Gwenda and Giles Reed.) They had two servants, a nurse, and a gardener. Although it is said that Helen had no money as a girl, the description of the clothes that were packed when she supposedly ran away indicate that she was well dressed and consequently had some money by then. (Cf a “grey and silver” evening dress, “gold brocade evening shoes”, “green tweed” and “lace blouses” [118].) Her social position is discussed in that way that it is made clear that one of her former boyfriends, Jackie Afflick, who was a clerk, was below her. I believe that, based on the difference with this boyfriend, Helen was middle-class before the marriage. Kelvin Halliday was a Major in the British Army but resigned when his wife had died in India. Because he and Helen could afford to rent St

Catherine's (and Kelvin wanted to buy it) and were able to employ the necessary servants, I would say that they were middle-class. I do not think that they were upper-middle-class as it is said that the villa they lived in is a small one.

Léonie was Gwenda's Swiss nurse. She believed Kennedy when he told her that Kelvin had committed the crime and she took his hush money because she was afraid of getting involved with the police. This suggests untrustworthiness. As she is a servant, she is lower-class.

Lily Kimble had been in service at St Catherine's. Now she is a "Middle-aged country woman" (179). Lily speaks a sloppy language, which is called "a common way of speaking" (117-18) by the other servant. For example, "Seems to me they might be meaning Mrs Halliday as I was in service with at St Catherine's. Took it from Mrs Findeyson, they did, she and 'er 'usband. [...] Yes, and she was sister to Dr Kennedy, him as always said I ought to have had my adenoids out" (101). The letter she writes to Dr Kennedy is even sloppier: for example, "I'd be grateful if you could give me advise about the enclosed wot i cut out of paper. I been thinking and i talked it over with mr Kimble, but i don't know wots best to do about it" (162). All of this leads me to believe that Lily must be lower-class.

Mrs Cocker is the cook who works for Giles and Gwenda. She is "a lady of condescending graciousness" (15). She puts on a "genteel" accent in order to suggest that she is of a better class than she really is. (Cf "It is *quait* a *naice* room, madam, though small" [emphasis added] [16].) It matches her "condescending graciousness". As she is a servant putting on an accent, I think she is lower-class.

Gwenda and Giles both come from New Zealand but have an English background and were brought up as orphans. They are "reasonably well off" (8) and able to buy Hillside, which is "a small white Victorian villa" (9) near the coast. In the state they buy it, it has, among other things, "seven bedrooms" (11) and a "flagged terrace [...] [with] a stretch of

lawn below” (10). They also have enough money left to pay workmen to make some changes and to build some bathrooms. On top of that, they also can afford a gardener and a cook. Neither Giles nor Gwenda are “a bit highbrow” (19): they are used to go to “musical shows” (25) but not to “first-rate theatrical productions” (27). Based on the size of the villa, their having enough money to buy it and to pay for workmen and servants, I believe that they are middle-class. They cannot be upper-class or upper-middle-class as they then would have bought a bigger villa. They cannot be lower-class either as they then probably would not have had the means to buy a villa.

The above division of the victims into social classes appears in the following table.

Table 7

Victims Allocated to Social Classes

Victims	Upper-class	Upper-middle-class	Middle-class	Lower-middle-class	Lower-class
Colonel Protheroe		1			
°Hawes			1		
Pamela Reeves				1	
Ruby Keene					1
°Mr Jefferson	1				
Mrs Symmington		1			
Agnes					1

Woddell					
°Megan Hunter		1			
Rudi Scherz					1
Dora “Bunny” Bunner			1		
Miss Murgatroyd			1		
°Mitzi					1
Christian Gulbrandsen	1				
Alex Restarick			1		
Ernie Gregg					1
Rex Fortescue			1		
Adele Fortescue			1		
Gladys Martin					1
Mrs Quimper			1		
Alfred Crackenthorpe			1		
Harold Crackenthorpe		1			
Heather Badcock			1		

Ella Zielinsky				1	
Giuseppe					1
Major Palgrave			1		
Victoria Johnson					1
Lucky Dyson			1		
°Molly Kendal			1		
Michael Gorman					1
Bess Sedgwick	1				
Verity Hunt		1			
Nora Broad					1
Elizabeth Temple		1			
°Jane Marple		1			
Helen Kennedy			1		
Kelvin Halliday			1		
Léonie					1
Lily Kimble					1
°Mrs Cocker					1

°Gwenda Reed			1		
°Giles Reed			1		
Total (41)	3	7	16	2	13

°attempted murder

Out of forty-one victims, three are of the upper-class, seven of the upper-middle-class, sixteen of the middle-class, two of the lower-middle-class and thirteen of the lower-class. This means that most victims come from the middle-classes (61%), of which 17% is of the upper-middle-class, 39% of the middle-class and 5% of the lower-middle-class. They are followed by 32% lower-class victims (which is half of the number for the middle-classes) and by 7% upper-class victims. The pattern that I have established for the murderers is thus repeated in the victims' case: the majority come from the middle-classes. Light's assertion that "it is the middle classes who are the murdering classes', [...] and their victims are their own selves" (97), seems right in this respect. This also means that Christie follows the convention established in the Golden Age that "The criminal comes from among the social circle of the victim" (Knight, "The Golden Age" 78). Possible reasons for this and a reflection on the variety of characters that belong to the middle-classes are cited in 2.1.1.1. Something that is different from the murderers' situation is that the victims are allocated to all social classes. This suggests to me that Christie is more careful to vary the victims' social status than the murderers'. A possible explanation for this might be Christie's comment in her autobiography that she has "got more interest in my victims than my criminals" (440). This would mean that her attitude differs from that of other crime writers as "Every murder mystery requires a victim, but until recently writers devoted far more attention to *suspects and culprits" (Edwards 478).⁹ Next to that, the victims are higher in number than the murderers, which allows for more variation.

2.2.1.2. Motives to die for by social class

I have investigated in 2.1.1.2. whether it is possible to allocate certain motives to a social class of murderers. Drawing on my findings there, I examine in this section whether a certain social class of victims is killed for a specific motive and whether some social classes of victims are killed for the same reasons. In order to comment on this, I draw a table illustrating which motive applies to each social class of victims. This is based on table 7 and the information in 2.1.1.2.

Table 8

Motives to Kill the Victims by Social Class

Motives/ Social class	Upper- class	Upper- middle- class	Middle- class	Lower- middle- class	Lower- class
Passion	1	3	2		1
Fear of exposure	1	3	8	1	9
Money	2	2	5	1	4
Revenge			1		1
Total (45)	4	8	16	2	15

As for the results, the victims of the upper-class are killed because of passion, fear of exposure and money. The upper-middle-class is killed for the same reasons. The middle-class falls victim to all motives: passion, fear of exposure, money and revenge. The lower-middle-class is only killed because of fear of exposure and money. The lower-class is killed for all motives.

In this case patterning occurs as the upper-class and the upper-middle-class victims are killed for the same reasons. The middle-class and the lower-class are both killed for all motives. The lower-middle-class is killed for the least number of motives. Looking at the motives themselves, only revenge is a motive for which the least number of social classes are killed. From this perspective, the other three motives are varied among the social classes. This points to Agatha Christie using variation for the victims in this case, for which the explanation is the same as in 2.2.1.1.: the high number of characters and Christie's preference for victims. At the same time, patterning is going on in the sense that certain social classes are murdered for nearly parallel motives. From the perspective of the reader, this means that he cannot entertain the hope of predicting what the motive is for which the victim is killed once he has established what the victim's social class is (one motive excepted).

The conclusion for this section is that with regard to the victims' social class, Agatha Christie uses the same patterning as is the case for the murderers: the majority of victims come from the middle-classes. With regard to which motives the victims are killed for, Christie uses both patterning and variation: some social classes are killed for parallel motives but three out of four motives are nearly equally distributed among the social classes of victims. Compared to the murderers, more patterning occurs in the victims' case, as the social classes of murderers do not kill for exact parallel motives. The distribution of motives among the social classes is varied for both murderers and victims, though.

2.2.2. Sex of the characters

In this section, I look at the sex of the victims in order to find out whether in the Miss Marple novels as many male as female victims occur or not. I then compare these numbers to those of the murderers in the corresponding chapter. Next, I investigate whether male and

female victims come from different social classes and I compare this to the murderers. After this, I examine whether male and female victims die for different motives. Finally, I find out whether male murderers kill male victims and whether female murderers kill female victims.

Table 9

The Sex of the Victims

Victims	Male	Female
Colonel Protheroe	1	
°Hawes	1	
Pamela Reeves		1
Ruby Keene		1
°Mr Jefferson	1	
Mrs Symmington		1
Agnes Woddell		1
°Megan Hunter		1
Rudi Scherz	1	
Dora “Bunny” Bunner		1
Miss Murgatroyd		1

°Mitzi		1
Christian Gulbrandsen	1	
Alex Restarick	1	
Ernie Gregg	1	
Rex Fortescue	1	
Adele Fortescue		1
Gladys Martin		1
Mrs Quimper		1
Alfred Crackenthorpe	1	
Harold Crackenthorpe	1	
Heather Badcock		1
Ella Zielinsky		1
Giuseppe	1	
Major Palgrave	1	
Victoria Johnson		1
Lucky Dyson		1
°Molly		1

Kendal		
Michael Gorman	1	
Bess Sedgwick		1
Verity Hunt		1
Nora Broad		1
Elizabeth Temple		1
°Jane Marple		1
Helen Kennedy		1
Kelvin Halliday	1	
Léonie		1
Lily Kimble		1
°Mrs Cocker		1
°Gwenda Reed		1
°Giles Reed	1	
Total (41)	15	26

Female victims are clearly in the majority: twenty-six female victims outnumber fifteen men. This means that in the Miss Marple novels, 63% of the victims are women, whereas only 37% of the victims are men. The reader has thus a fair chance of guessing that

the victim will be a woman as nearly two thirds of the victims are female. In this case, Christie makes it easy for the reader by using less variation. If I compare this to the number of male and female murderers in section 2.1.2., then it becomes clear that Christie is more careful to vary the murderers' sex, as I have shown that 57% male murderers and 43% female murderers occur.

Looking at the number of male and female victims by novel, the picture is more varied:

Table 10

Male and Female Victims by Novel

Novel	Male	Female
The Murder at the Vicarage	2	
The Body in the Library	1	2
The Moving Finger		3
A Murder Is Announced	1	3
They Do It with Mirrors	3	
A Pocket Full of Rye	1	2
4.50 from Paddington	2	1
The Mirror Crack'd from Side to Side	1	2
A Caribbean Mystery	1	3
At Bertram's Hotel	1	1

Nemesis		4
Sleeping murder	2	5

In eight novels out of twelve, both male and female victims occur. Out of the four remaining novels, two male victims and two female victims occur separately in two novels each. This means that male and female victims occur together in two thirds of these novels, whereas they occur separately in one third. If I compare this to the murderers, then I can conclude that even though there are significantly more female victims, they do not play as important a role as the female murderers. I have shown that half of the novels feature female murderers, in which they only occur together with a male murderer twice. The female victims occur separately in only two novels but are combined with men in eight novels. As Christie gives more prominence to female murderers, the convention in “the detective story formula that the victim [...] is usually the character of least interest” seems right with regard to the sex of the victims (Cawelti 92). This runs counter to Christie’s assertion that the victims interest her more than the murderers.

I must conclude that Christie uses patterning in the sense that most victims are women and that they mostly occur together with male victims. Yet Christie still creates variation by novel so that the reader cannot rely on this pattern for all novels.

2.2.2.1. Allocation of male and female victims to social classes

In order to examine whether male and female victims come from different social classes, I add table 7 to table 9. I then discuss the results.

Table 10

Male and Female Victims by Social Class: Linking Table 7 to Table 9

Sex/ social class	Upper-class	Upper-middle-class	Middle-class	Lower-middle-class	Lower-class
Male	2	2	7		4
Female	1	5	9	2	9
Total (41)	3	7	16	2	13

Male and female victims are distributed among nearly all social classes: only men are not present in the lower-middle-class. Out of forty-one characters, two men are of the upper-class, whereas one woman belongs to this class. Another two men come from the upper-middle-class and five women belong to this class. Seven men are outnumbered by nine women in the middle-class, two women belong to the lower-middle-class, and four men are outnumbered by nine women in the lower-class. In other words, 5% male victims and 2% female victims are of the upper-class, 5% men and 12% women are of the upper-middle-class, 17% male victims and 22% female victims are of the middle-class, only 5% women is of the lower-middle-class, and 10% male and 22% female victims come from the lower-class.

The conclusion that I can draw from this is that with the exception of the lower-middle-class, male and female victims do not seem to come from different social classes, even though they are not equally divided among these classes. As it is only possible to predict that no male victim will come from the lower-middle-class, this means that Christie thus uses enough variation.

Compared to the results of the murderers in 2.1.2.1., the overall conclusion is the same: neither male and female murderers nor male and female victims come from different social classes. What is different, is that male and female victims are more varied among the

social classes than the murderers. This can be explained both by the higher number of victims and by Christie's interest in them.

2.2.2.2. Motives to die for by sex

Based on my findings in 2.2.1.2, I investigate whether male and female victims are killed for different motives. In order to find this out, I draw table 11, which is based on table 8 and table 9.

Table 11

Motives to Kill the Victims by Sex

Motives/sex	Male	Female
Passion	3	4
Fear of exposure	8	14
Money	7	7
Revenge		2
Total (45)	18	27

The motive of passion kills three men and four women, fear of exposure kills eight men and fourteen women, money kills both seven men and seven women, and revenge only kills two women. Patterning occurs in the sense that revenge is a reason to kill only women for. As the other three motives are distributed among both men and women, this means that there is still enough variation. The reader will not be able to predict which motive the victims are killed for (one motive excepted). This means that three out of the four motives guide both male and female murderers and are a reason to kill both male and female victims for.

2.2.2.3. Murderers and victims' sex compared

As I have shown the murderers' sex in 2.1.2, the victims' sex in 2.2.2., and which murderer kills which victims, this now enables me to determine whether male murderers kill male victims and whether female murderers kill female victims. I collect this information in the tables below. The reader will remember that I have shown in 2.1.2. that male and female murderers sometimes operate together. In 2.1.1.2., I explicitly state which murderer kills which victim, which means that the "murderous partnerships" are cancelled for individual murders.

Table 12

Male Murderers and Their Victims

Male murderers	Male victims	Female victims
Lawrence Redding	1	
Mark Gaskell		1
Mr Symmington		3
Lewis Serrocold	3	
Lancelot Fortescue	1	2
Dr Quimper	2	1

Tim Kendal	1	3
Dr James Kennedy	2	5
Total victims (25)	10	15

At first sight, male murderers kill both male and female victims. When you look at it more into detail, you see that out of the eight murderers, two (25%) kill only men and another two kill only women. This means that half of the male murderers (50%) kill victims of both sexes and that another half kills only one sex. Numbers are thus fifty-fifty.

Table 13

Female Murderers and Their Victims

Murderers	Male victims	Female victims
Mrs Anne Protheroe	1	
Josephine “Josie” Turner	1	1
Miss Charlotte Blacklock	1	3
Marina Gregg	1	2

Elvira Blake	1	1
Clotilde Bradbury- Scott		4
Total victims (16)	5	11

As for the female murderers, at first sight it looks like they kill victims of both sexes. A more detailed look shows that one murderess (16.6%) kills only men and that another kills only women. This means that out of the six murderesses, four (66.7%) kill victims of both sexes, whereas two (33.3%) kill only one sex.

If I compare the results of both tables, then I can conclude that female murderers kill more victims of both sexes than male murderers. The other way round, male murderers kill more victims of separate sexes than female murderers. This knowledge will enable the reader to make a good guess, but he will not be proven right in all cases. Again, Christie uses patterning to a certain extent but is careful enough to provide variation as well.

In this section, I have thus shown that patterning only occurs with regard to the victims' sex in the sense that most victims are women and that they occur with men in the novels. Otherwise, variation occurs as both male and female victims come from the same social classes (one class excepted) and as they are killed for the same motives (one motive excepted). This means that with the exception of the number of male and female victims, the other results regarding their sex are the same as in the murders' case. I have also shown that patterning occurs in the female murderers' preference for the sex of their victims as they kill more victims of both sexes than male murderers do.

An overall conclusion for this second chapter points to Agatha Christie using both patterning and variation for the victims. The distribution of victims among the social classes is patterned around the middle-class and some classes are killed for parallel motives. Variation occurs as the motives themselves are relatively equally distributed among the social classes. Patterning disappears in the same categories when the victims' sex is taken into account. This means that the results parallel those for the murderers.

2.3. The murder weapons

In this chapter, I look at the murder weapons that are used in the Miss Marple novels. In the first section, I first give an overview of the murder weapons that are used in these novels, to find out whether the claim that they are domestic is correct. Then I determine in which categories the weapons can be divided. This will make clear whether Agatha Christie varies the murder weapons. The second section ties in with the investigation of the murderers. I examine which murder weapons are used by a specific social class of murderers and whether male and female murderers use different weapons.

2.3.1. Kinds of murder weapons

Alison Light writes: "Christie's domestication of weaponry exhibits the same juxtaposition [...] of the macabre and the familiar. Although she does employ poison almost obsessively (though always in its domestic varieties – arsenic for dosing the dog, cyanide for wasp nests stolen from the garden shed) there is clearly a morbid pleasure in choosing the banal impedimenta of home life and wreaking havoc with them: the kitchen pestle, the meat skewer, the golf club, a paperweight wrapped in a sock – all make an appearance in a repertoire of everyday things to kill with" (94). In order to examine whether this statement

applies to the Miss Marple novels studied, I first have to establish which weapons appear in them. I therefore present the reader with an overview of the weapons that are used per novel, which I then put in a well-organised table.

The Murder at the Vicarage (1930): Colonel Protheroe is shot through the head in the vicar's study with Redding's Mauser 0.25 pistol with a silencer. Hawes is nearly murdered by substituting the pills he takes for headaches caused by sleeping sickness. What the poisonous substance is, is not revealed.

The Body in the Library (1942): According to Miss Marple, Pamela is first drugged probably by means of "an icecream soda" after which she "goes off into a coma". Mark then strangles her in Basil Blake's cottage with "the belt of the [Ruby's] frock" (214). Ruby could also have been given a drug first "probably in after-dinner coffee" (214). The murder weapon, however, is not known. According to Miss Marple it can be "an injection" or "a blow on the back of the head" (215). Josie also attempts to kill Mr Jefferson when he is lying in bed at night. She wants to kill him by giving him an injection with "digitalin", so that his death would be "thought due to his heart failing" (216).

The Moving Finger (1943): Mrs Symmington is murdered by swallowing a cachet with cyanide in it. The poison is at hand in "the potting shed" and "kept there for taking wasps' nest" (sic) (55). Agnes "was first stunned by a blow on the back of the head" and then murdered with a "kitchen skewer, sharpened to a fine point [...] thrust into the base of the skull" (93). Mr Symmington attempts to murder Megan as well. He first puts "a soporific in the milk she always had by her bed" (152). When she is fast asleep, he carries her downstairs and attempts to put her head into the gas oven.

A Murder Is Announced (1950): All the victims are killed in a different way. The first victim, Rudi Scherz, is shot "at close range" with a revolver. The second victim, Dora

Bunner, is Miss Blacklock's adored friend. She therefore gets a nicer death: she dies in her sleep after having swallowed what she believes are aspirin tablets. However, it is some other drug or poison that Miss Blacklock has put in an aspirin tube by her own bed, after hiding Dora's newly bought ones. (No police report on what the poisonous tablets actually are is given.) When Dora cannot find her own, she uses Miss Blacklock's tablets. After Miss Hinchliffe driving off and Miss Murgatroyd shouting after her, it begins to rain and Murgatroyd starts taking off clothes from the washing line. At this point, Miss Blacklock emerges and offers help. She takes off a woollen scarf and offers to put it round Murgatroyd's neck. Then she strangles her. Miss Blacklock tries to drown Mitzi in the sink after being accused of the murder of Rudi Scherz.

They Do It with Mirrors (1952): Christian Gulbrandsen is shot with "a small automatic pistol" (208). Alex Restarick and Ernie Gregg's heads are crushed with "the big counterweight" in the theatre (259).

A Pocket Full of Rye (1953): Rex Fortescue is poisoned with taxine, which is derived from yew berries or leaves from the trees in his garden. Gladys is strangled with a stocking (134). Adele Fortescue is killed with "potassium cyanide" (128).

4.50 from Paddington (1957): The doctor's wife dies from strangulation, an act that Mrs McGillicuddy witnesses. Alfred dies from poisoning with arsenic, which "hasn't any taste" (176). The tablets that Harold took looked like his regular tablets but they are "Aconite", and are "usually kept in a poison bottle, diluted one in a hundred for outside application" (202).

The Mirror Crack'd from Side to Side (1962): Heather Badcock dies after drinking a daiquiri, which has "six times the ordinary dose" (56) of a drug called Calmo in it. Put more scientifically, she dies of "four grains of hy-ethyl-dexyl-barbo-quindelorytate" (53). This drug is sold more in the USA than in England and is used because "It induces [...] a happy and

tranquil state of mind” (55). Ella Zielinsky has hay fever and uses an inhaler for it, in which “Prussic acid” (161) has been put. She consequentially dies of “cyanide poisoning” (161). Guiseppe is shot in the back (163-64). The kind of gun is not mentioned.

A Caribbean Mystery (1964): Major Palgrave has been given a “lethal dose” of what Mr Rafiel remembers as “di-flor, hexagonal-ethylcarben-zol” but which he thinks he does not remember correctly (90-91). The symptoms resemble those of high blood pressure combined with alcohol. Victoria is found stabbed in the bushes (74-75); the murder weapon is a “*steak knife*” (sic) (87). Lucky is drowned in the creek. Tim attempts to kill Molly by giving her, what Miss Marple suspects to be, “a lethal dose of narcotic” (150).

At Bertram’s Hotel (1965): Michael Gorman is shot with Ladislaus Malinowski’s automatic pistol (154). Elvira took it from his car because it was the only one she could get her hands on easily. Lady Sedgwick kills herself by driving “ninety miles an hour into the park railings” (178).

Nemesis (1971): Miss Marple suspects that Clotilde killed Verity in a less painful and less brutal way than Nora: “I think you gave her a drink of coffee or of milk, you gave her a painless overdose of sleeping stuff” (200). Nora Broad, on the other hand, is strangled first with Verity’s scarf and then Clotilde beat her head in to make her unrecognizable. Clotilde murders Miss Temple by hitting her with a boulder. She wants to kill Miss Marple by poisoning her, possibly with an overdose of a sleeping draught. Miss Marple suspects that Clotilde came up to her room to “make sure that I had drunk the milk, and was in an unconscious sleep from which presumably I would not have woken up again” (203).

Sleeping Murder (1976): Kennedy strangles Helen with his hands covered with surgical gloves. Kelvin commits suicide at the mental home by saving sleeping pills and taking them all at once. His suicide is caused by Kennedy’s making him believe that he killed his wife. Léonie is killed by an overdose of sleeping pills, which she got from Kennedy. Lily

Kimble is strangled but we do not know whether Kennedy used something to strangle her with. As no such murder weapon has turned up, we can assume that he strangles her with his hands. Mrs Cocker is nearly killed by drinking poisoned brandy, which was intended for Giles and Gwenda. The kind of poison is not mentioned. Kennedy nearly strangles Gwenda with his bare hands.

Table 14

Murder Weapons per Novel

Novel	Murder weapon
The Murder at the Vicarage	Mauser.25 pistol
	°Poison
The Body in the Library	Satin waistband
	Unknown (possibly an injection or a blow)
	°Digitalin
The Moving Finger	Cyanide
	Kitchen skewer
	°Gas oven
A Murder Is Announced	Revolver
	Poisoned aspirin tablets

	Scarf
	°Drowning
They Do It with Mirrors	Small automatic pistol
	Counterweight
A Pocket Full of Rye	Taxine
	Stocking
	Cyanide
4.50 from Paddington	Strangulation
	Arsenic
	Aconite
The Mirror Crack'd from Side to Side	Calmo
	Cyanide
	Gun (?)
A Caribbean Mystery	Overdose (di-flor, hexagonal- ethylcarben-zol?)
	Steak knife
	Drowning
	°Overdose (narcotic?)
At Bertram's Hotel	Automatic pistol
	Crash

Nemesis	Poison (possibly sleeping draught)
	Scarf
	Boulder
	°Poison (possibly sleeping draught)
Sleeping murder	Strangulation
	Sleeping pills
	Sleeping pills
	Strangulation
	°Poison
	°Poison
	°Strangulation
	°Poison

°attempted murder

What becomes clear from this table is that not every weapon that is used in the Miss Marple novels is domestic: pistols, a revolver, a counterweight and a boulder are hardly domestic. Other “weapons” cannot count as domestic either as they are actions instead of objects: drowning, strangulation, and a car crash. What corresponds with Light’s statement is that poison is used a lot: weapons are used 41 times, and poison is used in 19 cases (also counting overdoses). This equals 46.3%, thus poison is used in nearly half of the cases. Again, Christie combines patterning with variation per novel: poison is used frequently, but some novels have a high use of poison, others less and in some novels poison is not used at all.

An explanation for Christie’s interest in poisons and overdoses can be found in her biography: in 1915, Agatha Christie started to work in a dispensary where she learned about

medicines and poisons. Morgan notes that “In carefully ruled notebooks she described in alphabetical order the appearance and properties of various substances, the sources from which they may be derived, their active principles and the substances with which they are incompatible [...] There were notes on alkaloids, tables summarising the preparation of antimony, belladonna, digitalis, morphine, etc., with recommended doses” (70). Morgan also adds that Christie “was scholarly about checking medical [...] detail” (*Agatha Christie: a Biography* 324). Osborne recognizes the importance of this knowledge of chemicals: “She confined herself to what she knew and, by extension, what she could most easily imagine: hence, in her novels, many more deaths by poison than by, for instance, shooting” (193). A totally other explanation for Christie’s use of poison is that she “might have learned a lot about poison through the detectives of the now completely forgotten Welsh Frank Howel Evans. More than ten years before Christie, he put on an inspector Poirot (the ‘e’ is not a typing error) in five of his stories“ (Braeckman 6).¹⁰

As not all weapons are domestic in the Miss Marple novels, I divide them in other categories (which are my own). This categorization will help me to determine which murderers use which kind of weapons in 2.3.2. It is possible to allocate the weapons to five different categories: chemical, mechanical, actions, fabric and other. The first category comprises all poisons and medical overdoses, the second all kinds of guns, mechanical kitchen utensils, and other mechanical equipment, the third all weapons that can be termed actions, the fourth all clothes and other fabric and the last weapons that are not known or that do not fit in in the other categories.

2.3.2. Murderers and their weapons

In this section, I examine which social class of murderers uses which kind of weapon. I do the same for male and female murderers. Based on the categories established in 2.3.1.,

the allocation of murderers to social classes in 2.1.1.1., the sex of the murderers in 2.1.2., and the plot summaries, I gather the information in two tables.

Table 15

Categories of Murder weapons Used by Social Class

Murder weapons/ social class	Upper-class	Upper-middle-class	Middle-class	Lower-middle-class	Lower-class
Chemical		3	6	1	
Mechanical	1	3	2		
Actions	1		3	1	
Fabric	1	1	2		
Other		2	1	1	
Total (29)	3	9	14	3	

The upper-class uses mechanical weapons, actions and fabric, the upper-middle class uses weapons from all categories except actions, the middle-class uses weapons from all categories, and the lower-middle-class uses chemical weapons, actions and other weapons. Excepting the lower-class, a minimum of three kinds of weapons out of the five categories is used by social class, which means that the reader cannot predict which social class the murderer comes from once the murder weapon is established. This points to variation. Below, I investigate whether this variation still holds in the case of male and female murderers.

Table 16

Categories of Murder Weapons Used by Sex

Murder weapons/ murderers' sex	Male	Female
Chemical	6	4
Mechanical	2	4
Actions	3	2
Fabric	2	2
Other	2	2
Total (29)	15	14

Male and female murderers both use weapons from all categories. Male murderers use chemical weapons slightly more than female murderers. The old adage that murderesses prefer poison to kill with, which is also expressed in, for example, *Murder at the Vicarage*, does thus not apply to the Miss Marple novels. This means that “men can commit ‘women’s crimes’” and that Christie consequently “upsets the stereotypes she makes use of” (Shaw and Vanacker 33). This upsetting of stereotypes will mislead the reader who keeps the adage at the back of his mind.

The overall conclusion for this chapter is that Christie is more resourceful in finding weapons to kill with than is generally assumed. The different social classes of murderers make a relatively varied use of them, and this variation is even more pronounced in the case of male and female murderers. I have shown in the first chapter that a clear pattern is used for the murderers’ social class. The variety of murder weapons by social class can thus be said to make up for the lack of variety in the murderers’ social class.

3. Conclusion

Agatha Christie is often accused of being a formulaic writer who “rewrites the same novel under different titles”. In this thesis, I have attempted to find out the truth about this claim by examining the murderers, the victims and the murder weapons in the Miss Marple novels. These three topics are the most relevant ones to be investigated when studying detective fiction as they are, in my opinion, the ones that are most central to the plot. The Miss Marple novels themselves are, as said in the introduction, the ones to be investigated in order to arrive at an understanding of the variety -or patterning for that matter- in Christie’s work.

In the case of the murderers and the victims, I have studied their social class and sex in order to see whether patterning occurs. I have shown that with regard to the allocation of these characters to the social classes, the same patterning occurs in both: the majority come from the middle-classes. This means that the critics’ assumption is right in this case and this can indeed be seen as a formula. What my investigation contributes to this is that I have shown that there is a difference in the distribution among the social classes between the murderers and the victims as Christie is more careful to vary the victims’ social class, especially with regard to the lower-class. This means that she is more sensitive to variation than is generally assumed.

As for the use of motives, I have shown that she only uses four different ones, which is again formulaic. However, a closer look reveals that Christie is still able to create variation: the four motives are combined into eight variations and their occurrence varies from novel to novel. Moreover, when studying the murderers’ use of these by social class, the majority of motives are distributed enough among the social classes to prevent patterning. When examining which social class of victims dies for which motives, more patterning occurs as

some are killed for parallel motives. However, as most motives are relatively equally distributed among the social classes of victims, this means that variation still occurs.

With regard to the murderers and the victims' sex, all the patterning that readers pick up on disappears. One social class excepted, male and female murderers and victims come from the same social classes. With the exception of the motive of revenge, male and female murderers kill for and the victims die for the same motives. This, however, does not imply that their distribution among the social classes and motives is equal. The majority of murderers kill victims from their own class, but when it comes to the sex of their victims, male and female murderers have different preferences.

The investigation into the murder weapons contributes to an assessment of both Christie's capacity to vary the weaponry and the murderers. I have shown that the assumption that her weapons are domestic is not entirely correct. She creates enough variation in the kinds of murder weapons in order to distinguish between five different categories. This contributes to an investigation of her variation of the murderers as it allows to determine which social classes of murderers use a specific kind of weapon and whether the choice of weaponry differs by sex. The answer is that the social classes make a varied use of them, as do the male and female murderers. Any patterning occurring in the murderers' social class is made up for in this case.

This means that readers are right in pointing out that Christie uses certain formulas. What is generally not taken into account is her ability to create variation on other and deeper levels. In this respect, it is wrong to dismiss the stories as rewritten versions of each other. Readers who do so do not acknowledge her ingenuity and creativity. This also implies that the characters in the novels exist in their own right, and that the murderers and victims thus are "pieces on a chessboard, to be calmly considered along with all the other chessmen, their qualities, motives and opportunities weighed coldly" (Barnard 47). Readers turn to formulaic

literature both in order to “find satisfaction and a basic emotional security in a familiar form” and because “the audience’s past experience with a formula gives it a sense of what to expect in new individual examples, thereby increasing its capacity for understanding and enjoying the details of a work” (Cawelti 9). In this case, the readers who pick up on the blatant patterns and who turn to Agatha Christie’s novels because of this will still be surprised by the turns she can provide: “She knew the rules of the game and worked out every possible variation of them delightfully to trick her readers” (Keating 189). This talent, her “ingenuity”, does not only lead to admiration and appreciation. It might well lead to “the despair of later crime writers”, as Barnard puts it: “because she dared to think the unthinkable there is no trick in the trickster’s book, it seems, that she hasn’t thought of first” (47).

The answer to the question whether Christie is a formulaic writer or whether she creates more variation in her novels than is commonly assumed, remains subtle: on the one hand, she uses patterning and can be called a formulaic writer. On the other hand, she does not “rewrite the same novel under different titles” as she is capable of providing variation on other levels. As Knepper puts it: “Christie wrote formula literature, true. But she was amazingly inventive [...] and her success stems from her skill as a writer, not her incompetence” (“The Curtain Falls” 81). It is not for nothing that she is called the Golden Age’s “Queen of Crime”.

Notes

¹ This claim is made in *The Oxford Companion to Crime and Mystery Writing*: “Christie is primarily associated in readers’ minds with the Golden Age of crime and mystery writing” (Bisbee and Herbert 69). The official Agatha Christie website claims that “Agatha Christie is the world's best-known mystery writer” (“Queen of Crime”). Martin Priestman also draws attention to Christie’s domination of the genre: “The longevity of Agatha Christie and many of the other Golden Age writers [...] ensured their continuing domination of public perceptions of British detection from the 1940s until as late as the 1970s” (“Post-War British Crime Fiction” 174), and calls her the Golden Age’s “most successful performer” (*Detective Fiction and Literature* 152). Morgan writes: “Fashions in crime fiction have changed, but Agatha Christie's popular following is undiminished” (“Christie, Dame Agatha”).

As for terminology, different categories are used to describe Christie’s work and genre. Malmgren, for example, draws a distinction between “mystery fiction”, “detective fiction” and “crime fiction” and sees Christie as a representative of mystery fiction. He also indicates that this category is called “the ’whodunit’” or “the ’formal detective novel’” by others (118). Other writers, however, refer to Christie’s genre as detective fiction or crime fiction. See Shaw and Vanacker (27) and Morgan (“Christie, Dame Agatha”) respectively.

² Knepper indicates that this is a problem: “While Christie adheres to certain formulaic conventions in the Miss Marple series, the novels contain more innovation, variety, and literary artistry than is generally acknowledged” (“Reading Agatha Christie” 34). Also Morgan is aware of this: “Agatha Christie's work remains surprisingly provocative. Some say her books are formulaic, her characters class-ridden, her style undemanding” (“Christie, Dame Agatha”). Knight writes that Christie’s “technique is easily scorned as formulaic, naive, unlike the complexity of real human interaction” (*Form and Ideology* 124). Even Agatha Christie’s own statement about what provided the inspiration for the novel *The Body in the*

Library would lead readers to believe that she uses formulas as she compares the writing process to “the concoction of a new recipe from familiar ingredients” (Light 96): “In the manner of a cookery recipe add the following ingredients: a tennis pro, a young dancer, an artist, a girl guide, a dance hostess, etc., and serve up *à la* Miss Marple!” (sic) (Christie, *Author’s Foreword* 8).

³ Poirot, however, is also an important detective. This first investigator appeared in 1920 and was created by Christie because she wanted to have “a detective of a type which had not been used before” (Morgan, *Agatha Christie: a Biography* 77). Maureen T. Reddy sees him as Christie’s most important detective and thinks that Miss Marple is “her second most celebrated series detective” (193). Knight, however, thinks that both are “her most successful creations” (*Form and Ideology* 112). Christie has also created other detectives, of which the ones named on the official Agatha Christie website are Tuppence and Tommy Beresford, Harley Quin, Parker Pyne and Ariadne Oliver (“The Other Detectives”). Superintendent Battle is also named in *The Oxford Companion to Crime and Mystery Writing* (Bisbee and Herbert 68).

The dates of the novels given are the first publications in the U.K.

⁴ A similar statement is voiced by Light: “Her settings are assumed to be inherently backward-looking, her social attitudes simply snobbish, and her imaginary milieux an idealised picture of ‘the long summers’ of the English upper middle class in a tightly class-bound society. It is a view which has become even more entrenched in recent years as Christie has been elevated to something like a national institution, seen as a particularly home-grown variety of writer, ‘as English as Buckingham Palace, the House of Commons and the Tower of London’” (62). Knight writes: “The form of a Christie novel has usually been denigrated. The structure is acknowledged as clever, but the style and characterisation condemned as plain and boring. [...] A literary simulacrum of vitality, originality and constant variety is not

part of the equipment these novels offer their readers; but her formal patterns are consistent and controlled, powerfully supportive of the ideology dramatised in the stories” (*Form and Ideology* 121).

⁵ The term “feminine middlebrow” is explained by Humble as follows: “‘Middlebrow’ has always been a dirty word. Since its coinage in the late 1920s, it has been applied disparagingly to the sort of cultural products thought to be too easy, too insular, too smug. [...] One important reason, I contend, for the subsequent critical neglect of the major part of the fiction published in Britain in these years [i.e. the 1920s to the 1950s] is that it was largely written and consumed by women.” Agatha Christie is named as a representative of this “hybrid form, comprising a number of genres, from the romance and country-house novel, through domestic and family narratives to detective and children’s literature and the adolescent *Bildungsroman*” (sic) (1-4).

⁶ Also Light stresses that Christie reflects this social change in her work: “Christie’s fiction certainly suggests that the middle class between the wars was not one coherent grouping with a shared set of values and complacencies but continually fragmented factions, ill at ease and suspicious of each other, endlessly divided against themselves” (98).

⁷ Charles Osborne thinks that Mitzi is a “refugee from Nazi Germany” (214) but this is not explicitly stated in the novel.

⁸ I had only access to the Dutch translation of this book. Quotes are translated from Dutch into English by me and may therefore differ from the English original. Page numbers refer to the Dutch translation. See Works Cited for details.

⁹ Shaw and Vanacker, however, think that this statement is not true and that “It is criminality that interests Christie, and what to do about it once it has been discovered” (78).

¹⁰ The Dutch quote is translated into English by me. The original text is: “Laura Thompson, zeer karig met het vermelden van ander werk over Christie, zegt niets over het

speurwerk van Margaret Obase, die ontdekte dat Agatha misschien wel veel over gif heeft geleerd via de detectives van de nu compleet vergeten Welshman Frank Howel Evans. Meer dan tien jaar vóór Christie voerde hij in vijf van zijn verhalen een inspecteur Poirot (de ‘e’ is geen tikfout) op.”

¹¹ This is a genuine disease: Josephine Bell mentions it as one of the diseases that change somebody’s character. “*General paralysis of the insane*. This disease is caused by syphilis, and is fairly rare now, since it is a late manifestation of the disease, and most cases are treated and cured now in the early stages. In the first stage of G.P.I. the patient becomes restless and irresponsible, rather like a manic-depressive, with delusions of grandeur and so on. He is liable to all the anti-social and personally dangerous behaviour already described for manic-depressive psychosis, but his disease develops very differently, with death the inevitable sequel, after gross weakness, paralysis, and mental deterioration. The brain post-mortem shows extensive damage by the spirochaete” (sic) (18).

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Appendix: plot summaries of the Miss Marple novels

1. *The Murder at the Vicarage* (1930)

In *The Murder at the Vicarage*, two people are convicted of murdering Colonel Protheroe. They are his second wife, Anne Protheroe and her lover, the artist Lawrence Redding. Lawrence occupies the shed in the vicar's garden and is painting a portrait of Protheroe's daughter Lettice as well as of the vicar's wife Griselda. Surprisingly, Anne and Lawrence give themselves up after the murder has been discovered. Redding is the first one to walk into the police station and hands over the gun. When Anne hears that he has been arrested, she says that she is the murderer. They are, however, quickly cleared of the crime. That is because they can make everyone believe that they gave themselves up because they loved each other so much that they wanted to clear each other. On top of that, they have arranged the evidence in such a way that it would first incriminate them but when checked up on it would reveal that they are innocent. This is their technique to avoid suspicion.

The police start looking for another suspect and in the end it seems that they have found one in Hawes. The vicar finds him after he seems to have swallowed an overdose. He also finds the letter that Colonel Protheroe was writing when he was shot in the vicar's study that says that he has discovered that Hawes had stolen money from the church funds. It seems that Hawes has committed the murder and has kept the victim's note. At the end of the novel, Miss Marple solves the crime and asserts that the murderers are Anne and Lawrence: Lawrence has hidden the gun in the Vicarage and Anne, who arrives later, uses it to kill her husband. Lawrence returns to pick up the gun. He has substituted the note Protheroe was writing for another but has kept the original. He visits Hawes, substitutes one of his pills and puts the note in his pocket. If Hawes had been found dead, the police would have believed

that he had committed suicide out of remorse for the crime. A trap is set up because the police lack evidence and Anne and Lawrence are convicted.

2. *The Body in the Library* (1942)

This story again deals with two murderers: Josephine “Josie” Turner and Mark Gaskell. They are secretly married in the hope of securing the inheritance of Mark’s father-in-law Mr Jefferson. The latter has had an airplane accident in which his children were killed. It is assumed that a remarriage of his son-and daughter-in-law will infuriate him and make him cut them out of his will. Mr Jefferson takes a liking to Ruby Keene, Josie’s cousin. He plans to adopt Ruby and to give her £50,000, which means that there will be little inheritance money left for Mark and his sister-in-law Adelaide.

Josie and Mark decide to kill Ruby and to cover up the murder by switching bodies. Mark lures Pamela Reeves, a Girl Guide, to the hotel where Josie works with the promise of becoming an actress. Josie gives her a makeover, one of Ruby’s dresses and dyes her hair so that she looks like Ruby. Mark kills her and places her body at Basil Blake’s cottage in the hope of incriminating him. Basil panics and moves it to Gossington Hall. After this murder is completed, Josie also kills Ruby, whose body she dresses in the Girl Guide’s clothes. She steals a car of one of the residents at the hotel, which she drives to a quarry and sets ablaze. The fire makes the body unrecognizable and it is identified as Pamela Reeves, on the basis of Pamela’s Girl Guide button and shoe.

Miss Marple, who has been asked by the owner of Gossington Hall to investigate the murder, cracks the case. With the help of the police, she sets up a trap: Mr Jefferson has to announce to Mark and Adelaide that he will give the money he intended for Ruby to “a hostel for young girls working as professional dancers in London” (206). Josie and Mark are

frightened that they will lose the money again. Josie then attempts to kill Mr Jefferson but is caught in the act.

3. *The Moving Finger* (1943)

When Jerry Burton has to recover from a plane crash, he takes his doctor's advice and moves with his sister Joanna to the country. They settle in a house called Little Furze in Lymstock (6). Soon after their arrival, there is an outburst of poison-pen letters. Jerry and Joanna get two of the kind, saying that Joanna is not Jerry's sister at all. The letters upset the community and the local witch, Mrs Cleat, is suspected of being the letter writer. Mrs Mona Symmington, the neurotic wife of the town lawyer, is found dead at their house. The police are called in and they believe she committed suicide over a letter saying that one of her sons is illegitimate. The police analyse the letters and are looking for a female suspect. Next, Agnes Woddell, a maid at the Symmingtons, is found murdered in their cupboard. Some time after this, the police arrest Aimée Griffith, the local doctor's sister. Evidence is found at her home and the police have seen her typing a letter to Symmington's governess on the typewriter that is used by the poison-pen writer. Miss Marple, who has been asked to come by the vicar's wife, knows that the wrong person has been arrested. Based on what Jerry has told her during tea at the vicarage, Miss Marple puts two and two together. Helped by Megan, Mr Symmington's stepdaughter, and the police, she sets up a trap because she lacks evidence: Megan confronts Mr Symmington and wants his money in return for her silence about her seeing him touching her mother's pills. He gives her the money, even though he says he does not know what she is talking about. The police arrive when he is putting Megan's head into the gas oven that night.

4. *A Murder Is Announced* (1950)

Young Miss Charlotte Blacklock suffers from goitre and is treated by her father, Dr Blacklock. When he dies, her sister Letitia leaves her job with Randall Goedler and takes her sister to Switzerland in order to have the goitre removed. Randall Goedler had made a will in which he leaves all his money to Letitia if his wife Belle Goedler predeceases her. However, Letitia dies and the money is lost. Charlotte, who has heard that Mrs Goedler is dying, decides to pretend to be Letitia. In that way, she will get the Goedler money. She goes back to England and settles in a place unknown to her. However, when at the Royal Spa Hotel, Rudi Scherz, who had worked in the Swiss clinic, recognizes her. Charlotte decides to kill him and organizes a murder party. She pays him to announce the murder in the local newspaper (hence the title) and to turn up at her house waving a torch and scaring the guests. She then shoots him and pretends being shot at herself. The room being completely dark, she thinks nobody has seen her sneaking out of it.

Dora “Bunny” Bunner, an old schoolmate living with her, is the only one she has let in on her secret, although she has not told her about the murder party. Dora and Miss Marple have a conversation about the murder party and Dora tells her what she has seen. Charlotte Blacklock realizes the danger and decides to kill her friend gently with poisoned aspirin tablets. When Miss Blacklock passes by Miss Hinchliffe and Miss Murgatroyd’s house, she overhears their re-enacting of the murder party. Miss Hinchliffe is called away to the station and just as she is driving off, Miss Murgatroyd realizes whom she has not seen. She calls after her friend: “She wasn’t *there*” (sic) (228). Miss Blacklock then strangles her with a scarf. Miss Marple knows who the murderer is, and asks Mitzi, Miss Blacklock’s refugee maid, to help her to set a trap. When Inspector Craddock interrogates a number of people at Miss Blacklock’s house, Mitzi accuses her of being the murderer. Craddock passes it off as a lie and Mitzi returns to the kitchen. Miss Blacklock sneaks out of the room and tries to drown

Mitzi in the sink. Miss Marple saves her by mimicking Dora's voice. Sergeant Fletcher was also hidden in the kitchen in order to get evidence (214-35).

5. *They Do It with Mirrors* (1952)

Ruth Van Rydock, who worries about her sister Carrie Louise, asks Miss Marple to go to Stonygates, Carrie Louise's house. During her last visit to her sister, Ruth got the impression that something was wrong but she cannot put her finger on it. When Miss Marple has been made to feel at home in the enormous house, Christian Gulbrandsen, son of the late Eric Gulbrandsen (who was Carrie Louise's first husband), pays an unexpected visit. A little later, he is found murdered in his room. The murder is committed while the man pretending to be Edgar Lawson supposedly threatens and shoots at Lewis Serrocold, Carrie Louise's current husband.

Lewis and Carrie Louise run a juvenile delinquent centre on the premises. One of these delinquents, Ernie Gregg, boasts that he was able to get out of the guarded building on the night of the murder and that he has seen something. Alex Restarick, Carrie Louise's second husband's son, "got an inkling of the truth" (274) during a reconstruction in order to see whether he could have killed Christian. Both Ernie and Alex are found murdered shortly after.

Miss Marple realizes that Edgar Lawson's argument with Lewis Serrocold was staged in order to give Lewis an alibi while he quickly murdered Christian Gulbrandsen. The latter had found out that Lewis had embezzled money from the Gulbrandsen Trust –with which the juvenile delinquent centre is run- and had confronted Lewis with it. Edgar was willing to help Lewis, as he really is Lewis' son. Alex and Ernie had to be silenced as well. At the end, both Lewis and Edgar die when Lewis tries to save Edgar from drowning.

6. *A Pocket Full of Rye* (1953)

After a row with his father about a forged cheque, Lancelot Fortescue is kicked out of the house. He goes to live in Kenya in Eastern Africa but is still a junior partner in his father's firm. When he hears that uranium has been found in the Blackbird Mine in Eastern Africa, he goes back to England to try and become reconciled with his father Rex Fortescue. The latter, however, is not interested. Rex suffers from GPI ("General Paralysis of the Insane" [264]),¹¹ which means that he is very careless with the firm's money and engages in wildcat schemes. Lancelot realizes that his father is making the firm go bankrupt. He therefore decides to kill him. He has heard that blackbirds were both found in a pie and on his father's desk and realizes that Ruby MacKenzie must have put them there to frighten him. (Rex left Ruby's father to die in Africa after inspecting the Blackbird Mine.) Lancelot decides to use this event to divert attention from himself: he decides to kill his victims in a sequence corresponding to "Sing a Song of Sixpence". In this way, Ruby MacKenzie will become the prime suspect. Lancelot seduces Gladys Martin and gets her a post as parlourmaid in his father's household. She puts some taxine in Rex's marmalade, which he eats, and which kills him. Lancelot then silences Gladys by strangling her with a stocking. The next victim is Rex's second wife Adele, whom he kills by putting cyanide in her cup of tea. Adele would inherit £100,000 from Rex, which the firm would have to pay and thus be ruined. After Gladys' murder, Miss Marple goes to Yewtree Lodge to give the police information on Gladys, as Gladys worked for her and had no relatives. Miss Marple is invited to stay and solves the case.

7. 4.50 from Paddington (1957)

Mrs McGillicuddy witnesses the strangulation of a woman in a train that runs parallel with hers. As she is a friend of Miss Marple's, she asks the latter for help. Miss Marple travels the same route in order to determine where the murderer could dispose of the body. She

assumes that the body will have been thrown out of the train close to Rutherford Hall. She asks Lucy Eyelesbarrow to take up a post at Rutherford Hall and to hunt for evidence, while she goes to live in the town with Florence, one of her previous maids. Lucy eventually finds the body in a sarcophagus in the Long Barn on the property. Lucy, intrigued by the murder, stays on. She runs the household for Mr Crackenthorpe and his daughter Emma, who takes care of him. After the body has been discovered, the sons come home. The entire family falls ill after eating curry, which, according to their doctor (Dr Quimper), has arsenic in it. One of the sons, Alfred Crackenthorpe, dies of the poisoning. Another son, Harold, dies after taking poisoned pills. Miss Marple, who has been introduced as Lucy's aunt, visits the remaining Crackenthorpes. She brings Mrs McGillicuddy along, whom she has instructed to leave the room. Dr Quimper arrives and the family celebrates his birthday. When Mrs McGillicuddy enters the room, Miss Marple pretends to choke on a fish bone and Dr Quimper looks in her throat. Mrs McGillicuddy exclaims that Dr Quimper is the murderer she saw on the train. Miss Marple explains that the woman whose body was found on the premises was the doctor's wife. Quimper has also murdered Alfred and Harold.

8. *The Mirror Crack'd from Side to Side* (1962)

Marina Gregg, a famous film star, has come to live at Gossington Hall in St. Mary Mead. She allows a party in aid of St. John's Ambulance Corps to be held at the Hall. Heather Badcock, the secretary of the association, is taken upstairs to join a select group that are allowed to meet Marina in person. She tells Marina about a previous meeting they have had, when Heather had German measles. During this conversation, Marina stares over Heather's shoulder at a portrait of the Madonna and child. When Heather later spills her drink, Marina offers her the one she is holding. A few minutes later, Heather dies. It is believed that somebody tried to murder Marina, but has missed the target as Marina passed her cocktail to

Heather. Marina receives threats, and refuses a coffee on the film set that turns out to have arsenic in it. Ella Zielinsky, Marina's husband's secretary, dies next. She suffers from hay fever and inhales arsenic that has been put in the spray she uses. Guiseppe, Marina's butler, is shot dead in the Hall shortly after. Both are killed by Marina because they found out that she is the murderess of Heather, and because they tried to blackmail her. The last one to die is Marina herself: she dies of an overdose of sleeping pills. It is unclear whether she has taken an overdose herself or whether her husband administered it.

9. *A Caribbean Mystery* (1964)

Miss Marple is on holiday in the Caribbean. Major Palgrave tells her a murder story and offers to show her a picture of the murderer. While he takes it out of his wallet, he realizes that the actual murderer is sitting near him. Palgrave quickly puts the photo back into his wallet without showing it to Miss Marple and starts talking loudly about something else. That same night he is murdered. Miss Marple starts investigating but the picture is missing. She is also distracted by the different murder stories the Major has told the other guests at the hotel. Rumour has it that the Major was suffering from high blood pressure. It is assumed that he aggravated his condition by drinking alcohol, which resulted in his death. One of the Caribbean maids realizes that a bottle of tablets for high blood pressure was not present in the Major's room before the murder. She makes this known to the owners of the hotel in the hope of obtaining some money for her discretion but she is killed instead. Meanwhile, Molly, the wife of the proprietor, is suffering from blackouts and persecution mania. She finds the body of Lucky, another resident, in the creek at night. Miss Marple wakes up just in time to save Molly's life. It turns out that her husband Tim has wanted to kill her all along. Lucky was just a mistake: she had fair hair and the same scarf Molly has. Tim, who had arranged to meet his wife at the creek that night, drowns Lucky by mistake instead of his wife. When he gets back

to his bungalow, he finds Molly there and tries to give her a drink with an overdose in it. He has also killed the others.

10. *At Bertram's Hotel* (1965)

Miss Marple stays at Bertram's Hotel in London. This old-fashioned and respectable hotel is in reality a cover for the criminal owners and staff. England is suffering several big robberies. The money is taken to the hotel by the criminals and transported out of it by some of the guests. One of the masterminds behind the operations is Lady Sedgwick. She has a daughter, the Honourable Elvira Blake, whom she refuses to see but who is also briefly staying at the hotel. When Bess Sedgwick was young, she eloped with an Irishman called Michael Gorman. Her parents offered him money to get her back and then married her off to Lord Coniston, a wealthy man and Elvira's father. He died when Elvira was a young child but he has left her a large fortune. At the hotel, Bess meets Michael Gorman, who works there as a doorman. He reminds her of their marriage and she warns him not to blackmail her. Elvira overhears this conversation and goes to Ireland to check whether her mother and Gorman are truly married. When she finds out that this is the case, she shoots Gorman at the hotel and pretends to be the intended victim. She thinks that she will not inherit her father's fortune because his marriage to Bess was bigamous and therefore illegal. The police are trying to catch the masterminds behind the robberies and tell Bess that they know it is she. They also tell her that her friend Ladislaus Malinowski is suspected of the murder, as he owns the murder weapon. Bess decides to save her daughter and friend and tells the police that she killed Gorman. She draws attention to her having threatened to do so during the overheard conversation with him. She then smashes the hotel room window and climbs out of it. She escapes in her racing car but finally crashes into the park railings and is killed. The police only have her false confession and have no evidence to arrest Elvira.

11. *Nemesis* (1971)

Mr Rafiel, a rich man Miss Marple met on her holiday in the Caribbean (*A Caribbean Mystery* [1964]), witnessed Miss Marple confronting the murderer there. He has passed away but has left Miss Marple a mission on which she has to “serve the cause of justice” (27). Miss Marple receives guidelines to go on a coach tour. It turns out that Mr Rafiel has carefully planned where Miss Marple stays and whom she meets. Miss Temple, a former school-mistress who is on the tour as well, is Miss Marple’s first contact. She tells Marple that Verity Hunt, one of her former pupils, was engaged to Mr Rafiel’s delinquent son Michael ten years ago. They never got married because Verity was murdered. When the tour stops at the Golden Boar in Jocelyn St Mary, Lavinia Glynn comes to the hotel to invite Miss Marple to stay at her house. As this meeting has been arranged by Mr Rafiel, Miss Marple accepts the invitation. She also meets Lavinia’s sisters Clotilde and Anthea as they are all living together. She gets to know that Clotilde has adopted Verity Hunt when Verity’s parents died, and that Michael Rafiel was convicted of her murder.

While Miss Marple stays at the sisters’ house, Miss Temple is hit by a boulder when taking a walk. She is taken to the hospital and asks for Miss Marple. Before she dies, she asks Miss Marple to find out the truth about Verity. It is clear that Miss Temple has been murdered. After her death, Miss Marple does not join the tour but stays at the sisters’ again. In the meantime, she finds out that a local girl, Nora Broad, has gone missing around the same time of the murder. She also meets Professor Wanstead, “a pathologist and psychologist [...] interested in the [...] criminal brain” (104), who is sent on the tour by Mr Rafiel. He does not believe that Michael Rafiel has killed Verity. Miss Marple comes to the conclusion that Clotilde has murdered Verity. She also killed Nora Broad, whose body she dressed up in Verity’s clothes and whom she identified as Verity. The real Verity is buried in the sisters’

garden. Clotilde also threw the boulder on Miss Temple because she was going to meet the archdeacon to talk about Verity with him. Between the two of them, they might have arrived at the truth. Clotilde also tries to kill Miss Marple but this is prevented by the two security agents whom Mr Rafiel sent on the tour. Clotilde then drinks the poisoned milk intended for Miss Marple and in this way commits suicide. Michael Rafiel is released from prison.

12. *Sleeping Murder* (1976)

Giles and Gwenda Reed have come over from New Zealand and have settled in a house in Dillmouth. The house is familiar to Gwenda: she remembers, among other things, a door and garden steps that are now covered up. She always feels frightened when she goes up the stairs. When she goes to the theatre, accompanied by, among others, Raymond West and his aunt Jane Marple, the lines “*Cover her face. Mine eyes dazzle, she died young ...*” (sic) (27) from *The Duchess of Malfi* make her scream and run out of the building. Her childhood memory of seeing Helen being strangled in the hall and of hearing the murderer speak these lines has been triggered. She does not know who Helen is or who killed her (though she remembers seeing the hands of the killer). Gwenda and her husband embark on a search although Miss Marple has advised them to “let sleeping murder lie” (147). It turns out that Kelvin Halliday, Gwenda’s father, had taken her to England when she was little and that they lived in the house in Dillmouth together with her stepmother Helen Kennedy. Helen was the half-sister of James Kennedy, the local doctor. Kelvin has always believed that he killed Helen and went into a mental home of his own free will, where he committed suicide. It turns out that he never killed her, although he died believing he did.

Now the hunt for the murderer is on. Various men who have been in love with Helen and who thus had a motive to kill her turn up. During the search, Gwenda and Giles try to get in contact with Lily Kimble, who worked as a maid for Kelvin and Helen at the time. They

place an advertisement in the paper. Lily Kimble distrusts it and writes to the former doctor of Dillmouth, James Kennedy, to ask his advice. Kennedy shows her letter to Giles and Gwenda and they all wait for Lily to turn up at the doctor's house. Lily, however, has been murdered. The police now get involved and Gwenda tells them everything she remembers and everything she and Giles have done and got to know so far. The police decide to start digging at the garden steps and they find Helen's body. Mrs Cocker, a cook who works for the Reeds, steps into the garden at the moment that the body is discovered. She is shocked and needs some brandy. Gwenda pours her a drink, which nearly kills her as the brandy is poisoned. It is clear that somebody is trying to kill Gwenda and Giles. Once the police have gone, Gwenda is alone in the house. She is upstairs when Dr Kennedy enters. When he calls out for her in the hall, Gwenda suddenly realizes it is he who has killed Helen. Dr Kennedy comes up the stairs and wants to strangle Gwenda but this is prevented by Miss Marple. It turns out that Kennedy has also killed the Swiss nurse Léonie (who took care of Gwenda at the time). She had seen him digging Helen's grave in the garden.